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Protests persist as Rahul calls for joint 'resistance'

Around 150 detained in Delhi as political leaders, activists, youth groups continue protests seeking removal of CEC Kumar; Kharge demands dissolution of Lok Sabha, Assemblies over 'illegal' polls

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

As Opposition leaders, civil society activists, and youth organisations on Saturday continued their protests seeking the removal of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar and suspension of the special intensive revision of electoral rolls, the Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, launched the 'Satyagrahi' digital platform to map resistance movements across the country.

In a video posted on his social media handle, Mr. Gandhi said truth was being suppressed and that, as the Leader of the Opposition, it was his responsibility to help resist this.

Meanwhile, the Delhi Police on Saturday detained around 150 protesters, including All India



Supreme Court advocates Prashant Bhushan and Kapil Sibal, activist Yogendra Yadav, and AISA leader Neha Bora take part in the protest near Jantar Mantar on Saturday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

Students' Association (AIS) leader Neha Bora, activists Yogendra Yadav and Anjali Bharadwaj, and Supreme Court advocate Prashant Bhushan, as they marched towards Jantar Mantar to demand the removal of the CEC.

Independent Rajya Sabha member and senior Su-



He listed Gen Z, students, farmers, Adivasis, Dalits, and women among those involved in different struggles. “‘Satyagraha’ is an initiative to bring these voices together on one map,” he said, urging people fighting what they considered injustice to register their movements on the platform.

 Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh linked the launch of the 'Satyagraha' platform to the protests against Mr. Kumar.

nder Neha Bora take part in the
day. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

preme Court advocate Kapil Sibal also joined the march but was not detained.

In his post on X announcing the 'Satyagraha'

Referring to the police action during Friday's demonstrations, he said the "Home Minister's police" had displayed "barbarity" against people peacefully protesting on the path shown by Mahatma Gandhi.

In his post on X announcing the ‘Satyagraha’ initiative, Mr. Gandhi said people across the country were fighting for their rights and were “too often fighting alone”.

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Boiler blast at Sri City pharma unit kills five



Shock wave: Officials inspect the site of the explosion in Sri City, Andhra Pradesh, on Saturday. K.V. POORNACHANDRA KUMAR

N.S. Chowdary
TIRUPATI

Five workers were killed and one was severely injured in a boiler explosion at a pharmaceutical manufacturing unit in the Sri City Special Economic Zone (SEZ) in Tirupati district of Andhra Pradesh on Saturday.

The cause of the accident is not known yet. The explosion occurred at a unit of Tablets India Limited, which caters to exports.

The deceased were identified as Gourab Roy (35) of West Bengal; Chinna Mastan (48) of Cheviri in Andhra Pradesh; Ramesh (52) of Madharapakkam in Tamil Nadu; Mohan (28),

the boiler operator and a native of Naidukuppam in Tamil Nadu; and Vasu (32) of Tada in Andhra Pradesh. While Vasu died during treatment at a hospital in Chennai, the other four died on the spot.

Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu directed the district administration to provide all support to the victims and expedite relief operations.

On Saturday morning, District Collector S. Venkateswar and Superintendent of Police L. Subbarayudu, along with other officials, reached the site to oversee the relief efforts.

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3 FIRs filed over protest on SIR row; hundreds detained on Day 2

No individual or organisation named in FIRs, say police; protest outside Parliament Street police station after woman journalist alleges sexual harassment by male police officer; Rahul Gandhi condemns incident, questions Amit Shah

Shrimansi Kaushik Ashna Butani
NEW DELHI

The Delhi police on Saturday registered three FIRs in connection with Friday's protest near Jantar Mantar demanding the removal of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar over alleged irregularities in the ongoing special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls. Political leaders, civil society activists and student and youth organisations continued their agitation on Saturday as the protest entered its second day, with hundreds of people being detained again.

According to the police, two FIRs were registered at the Parliament Street police station and one at Connaught Place police station under various sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhi-



Protesters clashing with police personnel during demonstrations against CEC Gyanesh Kumar; a protester being detained near Jantar Mantar on Saturday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA/ANI

ta, including disobedience and obstructing a public servant. The police said no individual or organisation had been named in the FIRs.

On Saturday, hundreds of protesters marched towards Jantar Mantar amid heavy police deployment and barricades on roads leading to the protest site.

Traffic diversions were in place on Jantar Mantar Road and Raisina Road. The call for Saturday's protest was given by All India Students' Association (AISA) president Neha Bora.

The march began near Patel Chowk metro station and saw participation from multiple Left student or-

ganisations and Rajya Sabha member Kapil Sibal, among others.

"Women protesters, journalists, and lawyers were manhandled by male police personnel," AISA said in a statement.

Journalist 'harassed' Meanwhile, a group of independent journalists sat



on a protest outside the Parliament Street police station later in the day after a woman journalist alleged that she was sexually harassed by a male police officer while reporting on the protest. She also alleged that the police refused to register her complaint.

Delhi Police did not respond to the allegations.

Condemning the incident, Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi wrote on X: "A female journalist has accused a police officer of misconduct at Jantar Mantar. For hours, hundreds of journalists have been sitting there with just one demand: that an FIR be registered. Isn't that the police's basic duty?... Delhi Police comes under the Ministry of Home Affairs. Amit Shah ji, where are you? You have to answer for this."

Protest over 'unlawful' arrests linked to Noida workers' stir; 70 detained near Jantar Mantar

Shrimansi Kaushik
NEW DELHI

The Campaign for Release of Workers and Activists of Noida (CaRWAN) on Saturday staged a separate agitation near Jantar Mantar seeking the release of workers and activists jailed in connection with the April 13 Noida workers' protest.

More than 100 protesters marched from Patel Chowk towards Jantar Mantar. The Delhi police detained at least 70 of them before releasing them later in the day. The protesters alleged that they were manhandled and that female protesters were being held by male officers.

'Unlawful detention' CaRWAN demanded that workers and activists who had been "unlawfully held by Uttar Pradesh Police and incarcerated for over five months" be released immediately.



A protester in detention showing a placard near Jantar Mantar. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

"While there are protests going on against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, his daughter Medha Roopam, who is the District Magistrate of Gautam Buddha Nagar, issued NSA (National Security Act) detention orders against Satyam Verma and Akriti Chaudhary," CaRWAN member Anjali said during the protest.

Ms. Anjali said that while Mr. Verma, a translator and former journalist,

continues to be detained under the NSA, Ms. Chaudhary remains in jail despite the Allahabad High Court quashing her detention under the Act on September 2. Six others are also in jail and 11 FIRs have been registered against them, she said.

"The Allahabad High Court called the police investigation on the basis of which the order was issued a 'concocted story' while quashing Ms. Chaudhary's detention," Ms. Anjali said.

The protesters sat down near Jantar Mantar after the police asked them to clear the site. The police then allegedly forcefully took them into three buses. The detainees were later released.

"Female protesters were detained after 6 p.m.," said Chitranshu, a protester.

Delhi University professors Nandita Narain and N. Sachin also took part in the protest.

AUD students allege campus gates shut amid ongoing sit-in protest; university denies claim

Ashna Butani
NEW DELHI

Ambedkar University Delhi (AUD) students on Saturday alleged that the university had closed the gates of its Kashmere Gate campus to students as their indefinite sit-in entered its seventh day. The protest is against two notices issued on July 31 mandating per-

mission for gatherings and attendance requirements for PhD scholars.

Students and parents said no one was allowed inside the campus on Saturday, including some students who were scheduled to appear for an internal examination. The situation escalated late on Friday night after students alleged that security personnel

restricted the delivery of food and water. According to the students, three of them remained inside the campus on Saturday of their own accord, while nine others continued their protest outside the gates.

Meanwhile, the university said in a statement that students had been informed in advance that its

library, laboratories and certain blocks had been closed for maintenance and upkeep.

"One of the demands of the students was related to infrastructural issues on the campus, and in this connection, the university has been carrying out maintenance and upkeep on a regular basis," the statement read.

Over 2,000 kg firecrackers seized; 3 held

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Delhi police have recovered 2,101 kg of banned firecrackers and arrested three persons in connection with their illegal storage and transportation in Outer North district, an official said on Saturday.

On October 1, the police intercepted two vehicles on Urban Extension Road-II in Bawana while they were allegedly transporting firecrackers from Haryana to Delhi. About 1,350 kg of firecrackers was recovered and the drivers, Amit Gupta, 42, and Sunil, 42, were arrested. The police traced the consignment to a godown in Alipur, where they recovered another 751 kg from Manoj Kumar, 34, who was subsequently arrested.

A case was registered on Friday under sections of the BNS and the Explosives Act. The two vehicles used to transport the firecrackers were also seized.

CM lays foundation for waste processing, biogas plants in city

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Saturday virtually laid the foundation stones for new waste processing plants at Okhla, Singhola and Ghazipur, as well as a 300-tonne-per-day biogas plant at Ghazipur for processing biodegradable waste, the Chief Minister's Office (CMO) said in a release.

According to a separate release issued by the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD), the waste processing plants will have capacities of 1,400 tonnes per day (TPD) in Okhla, 700 TPD in Singhola and 800 TPD in Ghazipur.

'100 acres freed' Earlier in the day, Ms. Gupta visited the Okhla landfill site and said that over the past 18 months, 217.17 lakh metric tons of waste had been disposed of at the Ok-



CM Rekha Gupta virtually laying the foundation for the new plants in New Delhi on Saturday. ANI

hla, Bhalswa and Ghazipur landfill sites, freeing nearly 100 acres of land.

As per the CMO release, Ms. Gupta told officials that merely removing the waste lying on the surface would not be enough. She said along with scientifically disposing of the old waste accumulated underneath, the system for processing the fresh waste must also be strengthened immediately.

Court seeks report on plea seeking FIR against Gupta

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A Delhi court on Saturday directed the police to submit a status report on a complaint seeking registration of an FIR against Chief Minister Rekha Gupta over her alleged remarks likening Delhi government officials to "Hanuman".

Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate Ashwani Panwar of the Rouse Avenue Courts directed the Station House Officer of Kashmere Gate police station to file the report by October 15, the next date of hearing.

The case stems from a complaint filed by Ram Niwas Sharma, who alleged that Ms. Gupta, while speaking at an event on September 23, 2025, compared Delhi government officials to Hanuman and said they remembered their authority only when faced with a situation akin to having their "tails set on fire".

The remarks were allegedly made during the launch of a Delhi Transport Corporation inter-State bus service connecting Delhi with Baraut in Uttar Pradesh. Mr. Sharma said in his plea that the remarks had hurt his religious sentiments.

Timings

DELHI

SUNDAY, OCT. 04

RISE 06:15

SET 18:04

RISE 00:00

SET 14:02

MONDAY, OCT. 05

RISE 06:16

SET 18:03

RISE 00:35

SET 14:47

TUESDAY, OCT. 06

RISE 06:16

SET 18:02

RISE 01:43

SET 15:27

Delhi Weather

max min

Delhi City 37 23

Safdarjang 37 23

Palam 35 23

Delhi Palam Today

36°C

Morning will be pleasant with mist and haze. The weather will be dry and very warm with uneasy afternoon. Night also will be pleasant.

Delhi Palam Tomorrow

36°C

The weather will be dry. Day will be very warm with uneasy afternoon. Night will be pleasant.

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INBRIEF



Haryana BJP MLAs meet PM, take tips on serving people

Haryana BJP MLAs met Prime Minister Narendra Modi at his residence on Saturday and discussed how to serve the public in best way. BJP president Nitin Nabin, Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini, and BJP national general secretary in-charge of Haryana Smriti Irani attended the meeting. “It was a pleasure meeting all the BJP MLAs from Haryana at 7, Lok Kalyan Marg today. Had a very meaningful interaction with them on several topics,” Mr. Modi said on X.

Punjabi influencer Mad Sandhu shot dead in Amritsar

Punjabi social media influencer and makeup artist Mad Sandhu was shot dead by two motorcycle-borne unidentified persons in Amritsar on Saturday, police said. The incident occurred on Loharka road around 6 p.m., they said. Two unidentified persons, who were on a motorbike, opened fire at Sandhu and fled the spot, Additional Deputy Commissioner of Police Sirivennela said. He was rushed to a hospital where he succumbed to injuries, police said.

Panchayat elections in Rajasthan to be held in four phases from October 23

The Hindu Bureau
JAIPUR

Elections to the panchayati raj institutions in Rajasthan will be held in four phases – from October 23 to November 17 – and the results for zila parishads and panchayat samitis will be announced on November 20. The State Election Commission (SEC) released the poll schedule here on Saturday, while stating that 4.03 crore voters would be eligible to exercise their franchise.



State Election Commissioner Rajeshwar Singh

that the elections would be held for members of 41 zila parishads, 457 panchayat samitis and 14,403 village panchayats following delimitation and reorganisation of Panchayati Raj institutions (PRIs).

Polling for zila parishad and panchayat samiti members will be held in four phases on October 23, October 29, November 4 and November 14. Elections for the posts of panch and sarpanch will be held on October 25, October 31, November 6 and November 16 and the counting of votes would be taken up immediately after polling at the respective village panchayat headquarters. Elections for deputy sarpanch will be held on October 26, November 1, November 7 and November 17 for the respective phases.

As many as 45,384 polling stations will be set up across the State, while the model code of conduct came into force in the rural areas following the announcement of the election schedule. There will be 50% reservation for women in the PRIs. The number of electors in the villages has increased by 6.22%. “Elections for sarpanch and panch will be conducted using ballot papers, while electronic voting machines will be used for zila parishad and panchayat samiti members,” Mr. Singh said.

Man dies after relief packet dropped from chopper falls on head

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

A 58-year-old man died on the spot after relief material dropped from helicopter fell on him in flood-affected Saran district in Bihar, police said on Saturday. They said the incident occurred on Friday near a relief camp in Parshurampur village within Amnour police station limits. The police identified the man as Anil Kumar Singh. His son Avinash Pratap Singh said, “The helicopter was dropping the

relief materials in bulk, and one of the packets hit my father’s head, and another hit his chest, and he died on the spot.” Amnour Station House Officer Vimlesh Kumar confirmed the death; however, the exact cause of the death could be ascertained only after the post-mortem. In a separate incident, a woman and her two children standing on the roof of their house were injured when a helicopter dropping relief packets came close to the building.

SPOTLIGHT

Radheshyam Jadhav

(Names of all minors in the story have been changed to protect their identity) Most nights, Kirti, in her teens, is jolted awake by nightmares of a marriage ceremony she never chose: the raucous twang of a banjo band rattling out popular Hindi-film songs, garlands swaying chaotically, and a stranger, nearly twice her age, waiting at the other end of the mandap, where Kirti is dressed like the bride. Kirti’s nightmare is triggered by the harsh generational reality of child marriage, which continues to be practised by families across Maharashtra’s drought-prone Marathwada region. Here, child marriage is not simply a consequence of tradition. Families say fears over girls’ safety, so-called family honour, migration, and economic insecurity leave them with few choices. Activists point to predators, weak institutional protection, and a growing marriage market that exploits vulnerable families. The result is a cycle in which married minor girls often face violence or abandonment, and return to the same homes where the next generation of girls is growing up. Despite laws and government campaigns aimed at ending child marriage, breaking the cycle remains a long

and lonely battle for the girls who choose education and independence. Kirti lives in Kathoda, 27 kilometres from the region’s historical Beed district, with her maternal grandparents Suman and Achyut Ovhal. Suman says her own mother was married at 13 and hated it. “But then there was no other option and I was married at the same age. Mulgishyanizali ki gharatthevta yet nahi (Once a daughter attains puberty, she cannot be kept in the house),” says Suman. After she was married, she adds, her foremost responsibility was to deliver children, preferably sons. She birthed four daughters and then a son. A majority of children born to underage mothers are not delivered in medical institutions, even though there are some government hospitals in the region. In fact, the Aadhaar cards of many women here mention only their ‘tentative’ ages. Both Suman and Achyut work as daily-wage labourers, even though they own a 1.5-acre patch of dry land. They migrate to western Maharashtra and other States like Karnataka and Telangana to work as sugarcane cutters during the six-month crushing season – October-November onwards. Marathwada records high numbers of farmer suicides. In 2025, the region’s eight districts recorded 1,129 farmer sui-

Childhood: sold, silenced, stolen

In Maharashtra’s Marathwada region, child marriage persists as families grapple with fears over girls’ safety and so-called honour. Poverty and migration add to the problem, while predators, weak institutions, and a marriage market deepen their vulnerability



A family in Beed district, Maharashtra, where poverty, migration, and concerns over girls’ safety contribute to the persistence of child marriage. RADHESHYAM JADHAV

cides between January 1 and December 31, with Beed being among the worst hit, as per government data. In the remaining six months, Suman and Achyut work in their fields and take up odd jobs in their village. With an unsteady income and an uncertain future, Suman got all her daughters married before they turned 16. They have all returned to her with their children following marital disputes. Suman and her husband have been convincing their son-in-laws to reconcile with their respective spouses. Trapped into tradition Kirti’s mother, Chaya, has been living with her parents for a few months. Every few months her husband leaves her and she returns to her maternal home. Suman refuses to say why he leaves or why the couple fight. She is worried he will not come back if he comes to know about the matter being discussed publicly. Kirti has witnessed her mother suffer through domestic violence and it colours her views on marriage. She is reticent and refuses to speak to strangers.

At the mention of school, her eyes twinkle, yet she doesn’t speak much. Circumstances have forced her to mature beyond her years and any talk of marriage brings her to tears. Chaya blames her mother for “destroying” her life by not allowing her to finish school. Yet, even as Chaya complains, she remains unsure whether she can avoid repeating her mother’s mistake and enable Kirti to study as she wishes. Chaya, who is a mother to three girls, including Kirti, works as a daily-wager and sometimes joins her husband as a sugarcane-cutter. Suman does see child

marriage as a social evil, but also explains how society is unsafe for girls. “There are predators all around. As daily-wage workers, we cannot take our daughters when we migrate for months as they are unsafe in a new place; we cannot leave them home, because they are unsafe alone,” she says. For Achyut, the family’s respect in society rests upon a singular, unyielding pillar – ijjar (honour) that is inextricably bound to a girl’s character. The girl’s character is measured solely by the preservation of her virginity. He believes that if a girl elopes, is molested, abducted, or raped, it is an insult to the family.

The best solution, in his view, is to marry the girl off as soon as possible so that the responsibility shifts to her husband. The Bal Vivah Mukta Bharat campaign by the Government of India aims to reduce the prevalence of child marriage by 10% by 2026 and make India child-marriage free by 2030. Maharashtra has the highest number of child marriage prevention officers at 21,196, as per government data. But Achyut has a different take on the issue. “Everyone condemns child marriage and talks about ending this custom, but what about the predators who force parents into marrying off their daughters early?” he says. Prey for predators Tatwashi Kamble, a child rights activist based in Beed, highlights that addressing these issues exposes a deeper systemic crisis involving political influence in molestation, rape and abduction. He points out that predators backed by political influence frequently target vulnerable minors and pressure them to flee, leaving poor parents largely

powerless to speak out due to severe intimidation. In Aher Dhanora village, some four kilometres away from Beed, a local youth lured a 15-year-old girl away from home and raped her. He continued to sexually assault her in the following days. When she resisted, he blackmailed her, threatening to tell the village that she was no longer a virgin. When her parents came to know about this, they planned to marry her off. The local youth returned and demanded they pay him. In Kaij, about 50 kilometres from Beed, another family mustered the courage to seek justice for their 13-year-old daughter who was allegedly molested by a local goon. Yet, her parents were subjected to severe systemic apathy – the father and the girl were forced to wait 27 hours in the Kaij police station and government health centre simply to file a report and obtain medical documentation, say activists. They add that although cases of exploitation involving politically connected men, their associates, and local goons are widely discussed across Beed, fear prevents many families from speaking out. Brides for sale “A majority of families marry their daughters for security reasons, but many parents exploit their own daughters,” says Ashok Tangade, chairperson of the Beed District Child

Welfare Committee (CWC). In Shirur, 41 kilometres from Beed, a police case has been registered against the father and stepmother of a 15-year-old for forcefully marrying her off. The girl’s mother and maternal uncle claim monetary transactions took place before the marriage. Not all girls have a safe route home. A few years ago, 14-year-old Sheetal from Pimpla village in Beed wanted to stay home, go to school, and play with her friends. Married off by her parents to a local farmer, Dadasaheb Toge, she repeatedly returned to her parental home. When she resisted going back, her father, Prakash Bhange, strangled and smothered her to death in a sugarcane field, according to the police. Her father told authorities, “She wouldn’t listen.” “Girls are being treated as a commodity in the marriage market,” observes Tangade. The National Family Health Survey (NFHS-5) puts Beed among the districts in Maharashtra with most cases of child marriages: 43.7% of women aged 20-24 were married before 18. Parbhani, a district in Marathwada, recorded the highest rate at 48%. Activists note that these numbers represent just the tip of the iceberg in Beed. While authorities have intervened to stop about 800 child marriages in recent years, filing formal cases remains difficult. radheshyamj@gmail.com



Strengthening ties: Leaders of the INDIA bloc constituents at the meeting held at Sathyamurthy Bhavan in Chennai on Saturday. PTI

TVK formally joins INDIA bloc; plans to join demonstrations against BJP and EC

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI



The various Tamil Nadu leaders of the Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) met at the Tamil Nadu Congress Committee’s (TNCC) headquarters in Chennai on Saturday and formally welcomed the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) into the alliance, led by the Congress nationally. The meeting was chaired by TNCC president B. Manickam Tagore.

We need to have a political understanding that Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Amit Shah are destroying the democracy in India

B. MANICKAM TAGORE
TNCC president

At the meeting, it was also decided that ‘Save Democracy’ protests would be organised at the district headquarters across Tamil Nadu on October 13 and 14 to highlight the issues surrounding the breakdown of democracy in India. Additionally, a protest will be held on October 15, in which INDIA bloc leaders will participate in Chennai. Mr. Tagore said TVK’s general secretary (Election Management) and PWD Minister Aadhav Arjuna, MDMK chief Vaiko, VCK chief Thol. Thirumavalavan, CPI(M)’s State secretary, P. Shanmugam, IUML’s K.A.M. Muhammed Abubacker, and CPI(ML) leader Chandra Mohan participated in the meeting. Other leaders, such as State Finance Minister Maria Wilson, Congress leaders K.V. Thangakabalu and K.S. Alagiri, State Higher Education Minister P. Viswanathan, VCK treasurer S.S.

Balaji, Congress MP Praveen Chakravarty, Tiruvalur MP Sasikanth Senthil, and Congress MLA Tharashai Cuthbert were also present. Asked if the DMK was invited to be a part of the meeting, Mr. Tagore said, “Everyone fighting the RSS-BJP’s rule can be a part of the INDIA bloc. We need to have a political understanding that Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Amit Shah are destroying the democracy in India. Our leaders have reached out to parties who should have come today, but I cannot talk about those who did not attend.” “You have been asking why the TVK was not participating in INDIA bloc meetings. Now, it has joined the alliance. Its leaders have said that they are ready to protest and burn the effigy of [Chief Election Commissioner] Gyanesh Kumar. INDIA bloc is strong in Tamil Nadu. We are going to oppose the RSS, BJP, and Gyanesh Kumar,” he added.

CM
YK

SP changes candidates for two MLC seats, fields BJP rebels

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

The Samajwadi Party (SP) on Saturday changed two of its candidates for the upcoming Uttar Pradesh Legislative Council polls, announcing the names of Akash Agarwal and Sanjayan Tripathi, both rebels from the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), who were demanding tickets from the ruling party. In Gorakhpur-Faizabad Teachers’ constituency, Dr. Tripathi has been named as the candidate in place of Kamlesh Yadav. The party has fielded Dr. Agarwal in place of Prakash Chandra Gupta in the Agra Teachers’ constituency.

“The leaders joining today have been declared candidates with the consent of the two previously announced SP candidates – Prakash Chandra Gupta and Kamlesh Yadav. All party workers and leaders will



SP president Akhilesh Yadav in Lucknow on Saturday. PTI

consider this election their own and fight it. Along with Dr. Agarwal and Dr. Tripathi, the party will work diligently to ensure the victory of all the declared candidates. Those who have made sacrifices today will always be respected, and when the time comes, they will be given a respectable place,” said SP president Akhilesh Yadav, addressing a press conference in Lucknow.

He alleged the education system has collapsed under

the BJP government with paper leaks ruining the lives of young aspirants. “Education and examination systems have collapsed under the BJP government. Uttar Pradesh has seen the highest number of paper leaks in 10 years. There is discrimination in government jobs. Under the BJP government, gangs have formed in the Education Department; the government has discriminated against and exploited teachers. SP will include the demands of unfunded teachers, Shiksha Mitras (contractual teachers), and the Old Pension Scheme in its manifesto for 2027 Assembly election,” he said.

“Both candidates were welcomed by Mr. Akhilesh. The decision will strengthen the fight for the cause of social justice,” said SP spokesperson Udaiveer Singh.

From Page One

Protests persist as Rahul calls for joint ‘resistance’

Escalating the face-off with the Narendra Modi government over the sanctity of the electoral process, Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge demanded the dissolution of the Lok Sabha and State Assemblies, saying that “all the elections were illegal”. He also said that Prime Minister Modi, Union Home Minister Amit Shah, and Chief Ministers of States were “illegal” occupants of their posts.

The National Students’ Union of India, the student wing of the Congress, staged a protest at the India Gate over alleged irregularities in the SIR process and demanded the arrest of the CEC.

Mr. Gandhi said the platform would allow people to share their stories and see who else was fighting similar battles. He also promised to take up their concerns “in Parliament, on the streets, through letters, wherever I am needed”.

In the accompanying video, Mr. Gandhi said protests relating to land, women’s rights, Dalit and OBC rights, education, and examinations were taking place across the country. “We want to help organise these protests, put them together on one map, and work together with you to see if we can help you resolve what you’re fighting for,” he said. “As the Leader of the Opposition, it is important for me to help people resist where truth is being crushed,” Mr. Gandhi said. “The truth is important. It is important at the highest levels, but it is important that we fight for it in every corner of the country.”

Later in the evening, he said the ‘Satyagraha’ platform had received over 10,000 responses in nine hours after it went live. “That’s how many struggles Indians are already fighting – quietly, convinced no one was listening. We are listening. Every submission will be read,” he said.

Mr. Ramesh alleged that the government had been formed through “stolen votes” and said the detention of citizens, students and Congress workers would not deter the protests. “The protests continue today as well, and people will keep raising their voices,” he said.

He said Mr. Gandhi’s initiative sought “to unite all those voices, no matter who is resisting or where”, adding that “our unity is our greatest strength”.

Mr. Kharge, speaking in Kalaburagi, Karnataka, said the Opposition would continue its agitation against the SIR and alleged that the exercise was adversely affecting poor people, workers, the uneducated and minorities. He demanded that fresh elections be held through ballot papers.

“Today, the entire country is being run on illegal elections. Modi is an illegal Prime Minister, Shah is an illegal Minister, and all the Chief Ministers who have been elected anywhere are illegal,” Mr. Kharge said, demanding that the Lok Sabha and State Assemblies be dissolved.

He also attacked the 2023 law granting immunity to the CEC and Election Commissioners for acts done in the discharge of their official duties. Referring to reports of objections raised by Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi over aspects of the SIR, Mr. Kharge said their concerns had not altered the process.

Boiler blast at Sri City pharma unit kills five

Health Minister Satya Kumar Yadav spoke to District Medical and Health Officer (DMHO) Balakrishna Naik over phone and directed him to ensure that the injured received quality medical treatment.

The DMHO told the Minister that emergency response teams, medical personnel, and other officials had reached the site and initiated relief measures. He told the Minister that the bodies of Gourab and Mohan were shifted to the Sullurpetta Government Hospital, while those of Chinna Mastan and Ramesh were moved to the Satyavedu Government Hospital for a post-mortem examination. The DMHO also informed that a woman, Krishnaveni (38), who sustained a leg injury, was treated at the accident site and her condition was stable. Two other workers, Ramu and Lakshamma, who were present at the accident site, did not sustain injuries.

The District Collector announced an ex gratia of ₹50 lakh to the next of kin of each of the deceased.

The Sri City SEZ management said it would bear the educational expenses of the children of the deceased. Eligible family members of the deceased would also be provided employment within the Sri City, the Collector said.

In addition to registering a preliminary case against those responsible, a special team, comprising senior officials from the Boiler, Factories, Industries, and Police departments, has been constituted to inquire into the incident. Strict action would be taken against those responsible based on the inquiry report, the Collector said.

Orders were also issued to suspend the Tirupati Boiler Inspector for negligence in discharging his duties, he said, while noting that this was the first such accident in Sri City since its inception. He further said that instructions were also issued to immediately conduct a third-party safety audit across all the industries in Sri City to prevent the recurrence of such incidents.

Pharma unit assures assistance

Meanwhile, addressing the media, Tablets India Limited Director Ajay Kumar said, “We are committed to fully cooperating with the government authorities and all concerned agencies in conducting a thorough investigation into the cause of the accident.” “At this difficult time, our immediate priority is to support the affected employees and their families...,” Mr. Ajay Kumar added.

9 lakh names dropped from electoral roll in Uttarakhand

Final roll contains 71.59 lakh names, including 1,29,872 newly enrolled voters; State to begin drive to enrol missing voters, with BLOs visiting homes to help eligible people fill Form 6, says CEO

Ishita Mishra
NEW DELHI

Around nine lakh names have been removed from Uttarakhand’s electoral roll through the special intensive revision (SIR). The final electoral roll was published on Saturday, carrying the names of 71.59 lakh electors in the State.

Speaking to the media, Uttarakhand Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) B.V.R.C. Purushottam said the final roll includes 1,29,872 newly enrolled voters.

When the SIR exercise began in June, the State had 79,60,762 registered voters. The first draft roll, published on July 14, contained 71,33,785 names.

The State accepted claims and objections until August 13, while hearings and disposal of cases continued until September 28, ahead of the publication of the final roll on Saturday.

“Compared with the draft roll published in July, the number of electors has risen by about 25,000, as 1,04,708 names were deleted following claims and objections, while more than 1.29 lakh names were added,” Mr. Purushottam said.

Sharing the gender-wise



Detailed exercise: The final electoral roll comprises 34,21,036 women, 37,37,701 men and 212 third-gender voters. FILE PHOTO

details, the official said the final roll comprises 34,21,036 women, 37,37,701 men and 212 third-gender voters. It includes 72,656 voters aged 18-19 years and 1,22,892 voters above the age of 80. The State has 12,543 polling stations.

Special enrolment drive

Addressing concerns over those who could not make it to the final poll list, Mr. Purushottam said people who were left out, as well as those who have become newly eligible to vote, can apply by filling Form 6 either online through the ECINet app or offline through their booth-level officer (BLO).

The State will now begin a special drive to enrol mis-

sing and eligible voters, following the nearly 10% decline in the electoral roll, with a large number of voters placed in the “uncollectable absent, shifted, dead, or duplicate (ASDD)” category. Dehradun recorded the highest number of such voters at 1,86,008, followed by Udham Singh Nagar with 1,77,673 and Haridwar with 1,30,203.

“A special campaign to enrol new voters will now begin. Under the plan, BLOs will compare the current roll with the pre-SIR list, identify voters who were earlier listed but are now missing, and visit them at home to help eligible people fill Form 6. They will also ensure forms are filled for first-time and young voters and

share the list with booth-level agents of recognised political parties,” the official said. He added that Electoral Registration Officers (EROs) would subsequently share booth-wise lists with party representatives.

Vote theft, claims Cong.

Meanwhile, senior vice-president of the Uttarakhand Pradesh Congress Committee, Suryakant Dhasmana, expressed dissatisfaction with the final electoral roll and demanded that the Election Commission (EC) make public the complete Assembly constituency-wise details of voters whose names were deleted during the pre-SIR and SIR exercises.

“They have deleted over 8.5 lakh names in the final list while 4.5 lakh names were deleted pre-SIR. This totals to the deletion of 13 lakh names in such a small State,” claimed Mr. Dhasmana.

He alleged that most of the deletions were carried out under what he described as a “vote theft” formula and claimed that irregularities in Forms 6 and 7 had come to light, following which the EC took a U-turn, raising questions over the exercise.

NHRC seeks report over minors at CJP protest in Mumbai

Chinmay Gaikwad
MUMBAI

The Mumbai Police registered a first information report (FIR) on Saturday against the organisers of a protest on Friday by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) and 400-500 unidentified persons. The National Human Rights Commission (NHRC), meanwhile, sought action-taken reports over a complaint which alleged that children below 18 years were involved in the gathering.

An FIR was registered at the Shivaji Park police station under provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and the Maharashtra Police Act, based on a complaint, made by Shivaji Park resident Siddhi Deolekar, which named CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke among others. According to the FIR, 400-500 protesters gathered near Gate No. 6 of the Shivaji Park grounds around 2 p.m. and remained there until 7 p.m. The police said the gathering took place on a road, disrupted traffic, and created a law-and-order situation.

Mr. Dipke organised the “Jail Bharo” protest demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar over irregularities in the special intensive revision (SIR)

Gathering took place on a road, disrupted traffic, and created a law-and-order situation, say police

of electoral rolls. Based on another complaint over participation of children in the gathering, the NHRC took cognizance of the matter under Section 12 of the Protection of Human Rights Act, 1993. The complainant, Satish Vaid, head of intervention, Sewa Nyaya Utthan Foundation, said photographs and videos of children in the protest were circulated on platforms. The rights body sought action-taken reports from the authorities within a week.

The complaint said a child was held above a crowd with the National Flag and a placard while slogans were raised and people recorded it all on phones. It said the discussions raised the premise that police may not detain children.

The Commission said the issue was not only the presence of children. It said if the allegations were proved, it would raise a concern about planning, mobilisation, or use of children with knowledge of their age and vulnerability. (With inputs from PTI)

On the draw



Police removing badges before detaining protesters, says CPI MP

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

CPI MP P. Sandosh Kumar on Saturday alleged that Delhi Police personnel have been removing or concealing their identity badges before detaining or using force against protesters and urged Union Home Minister Amit Shah to order a time-bound inquiry into the practice.

In a letter to the Minister, Mr. Kumar sought his intervention into repeated use of violence, arbitrary detentions and other un-

lawful practices by the Delhi Police while dealing with democratic protests.

The National Secretariat Member of the CPI was himself detained on Friday along with CPI workers and cadres of the AISF and AIYF during a protest against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar.

He expressed serious concern that the Delhi Police, which is directly answerable to the Union Home Ministry, has repeatedly responded to peaceful political mobilisation with

“violence, mass detentions, internet shutdowns and manhandling” instead of protecting citizens exercising their democratic rights at a protest site designated by the Supreme Court and the National Green Tribunal (NGT).

Citing the Supreme Court’s directions in *D.K. Basu v. State of West Bengal* and Delhi Police Standing Order No. 51, the Rajya Sabha MP said that identification is essential for accountability when the police exercise coercive powers against citizens.

India, Pak. summon diplomats over two men killed by BSF

Suhasini Haidar
Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

India and Pakistan summoned each other’s diplomats and traded charges on Saturday over the killing of two Pakistani men whom the Border Security Force said had attempted to infiltrate through the International Border along Punjab’s Tarn Taran district.

Pakistan’s Ministry of Foreign Affairs (MoFA) summoned the Indian Charge d’Affaires (CdA) in Islamabad on Saturday to protest the killings of men they said were “unarmed civilians”. Late in the evening, India also summoned the Pakistan Charge d’Affaires to reject the Pakistani statement and protested “the continued facilitation of illegal cross-border infiltration from Pakistan”.

After completing the post-mortem procedures, a senior BSF official told *The Hindu* that they handed over the bodies to Pakistani Rangers on Saturday.

Officials did not confirm whether any weapons had been found on the men, who had been accused of trying to infiltrate through the border fencing on Friday morning.

While the BSF said that they had shot at the men, including one who ran away, when they attempted to cross over at the International Border along Tarn Taran district, Pakistan’s Foreign Ministry accused the Indian security forces of using “unprovoked lethal force against unarmed civilians”.

“Such use of force was wholly unjustified and grossly disproportionate, resulting in the tragic loss of two precious lives. Pakistan categorically rejects any attempt to mischaracterise the deceased as ‘infiltrators,’” the Pakistan MoFA said in a statement.

However, the Ministry of External Affairs said that the incident highlighted “a clear pattern of repeated cross-border movement by armed narcotics syndicates operating from Pakistan”

Citizen groups slam Rijiju’s description of Manipur issue

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

A coalition of 14 civil society organisations in Manipur has criticised Union Minority Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju for describing the prolonged violence in the State solely as a communal conflict.

The coalition, which was at the forefront of a movement that made the Centre defer the Census exercise in Manipur, said the conflict was linked to armed groups. It questioned the Centre’s approach to these groups despite failing to address the security dimensions of the crisis.

“The Union Minister’s description of the Manipur conflict and his emphasis on dialogue reflected an ‘inadequate understanding’ of the security scenario,” said Shanta Nahakpam, the coalition’s convenor.

“The violence has involved armed extremist groups, and attacks on civilians and villages,” he told journalists in Imphal on Saturday.

Insulting people’s mandate old habit of Cong.: Chouhan

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Saturday said Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge calling Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Home Minister Amit Shah “illegal” amounted to an insult to constitutional institutions and the people’s mandate.

“The country’s democracy stands firmly on the foundation of the Constitution given by Babasaheb Ambedkar, and the people will continue to respond to such false and baseless statements democratically time and again,” Union Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan said in a statement.

“Mr. Kharge’s statement, made at the direction of Leader of the Opposition [in the Lok Sabha] Rahul Gandhi, reflects the Congress’ frustration and mindset following electoral defeats,” Mr. Chouhan said.

Stating that the Congress chief’s remarks were yet another example of the party’s “longstanding



Shivraj Singh Chouhan

practice of attacking constitutional institutions”, he said, “Whenever the people of the country reject the Congress in elections, it begins conspiring to discredit democracy, the Election Commission, EVMs (Electronic Voting Machines), and the mandate of the people.”

“Does democracy, in the Congress party’s view, become legitimate only when the Gandhi family or the Congress party is in power?” he asked. Mr. Chouhan said the Congress had not questioned EVMs when it won elections in Karnataka, Telangana, or Himachal Pradesh.

Fighter jet deal likely by end of fiscal year: IAF chief

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI

India expects to finalise the much-awaited Multi-Role Fighter Aircraft (MRFA) deal by the end of the current financial year, provided the ongoing process progresses as planned, Air Chief Marshal A.P. Singh said on Saturday.

The proposed acquisition of 114 fighter aircraft is at the price negotiation stage, with discussions also under way on other critical aspects of the programme.

In February, the government cleared the long-pending proposal to procure 114 Rafale fighter jets from France through a government-to-government framework.

Speaking at a press conference ahead of Air Force Day on October 8, Mr. Singh said the IAF could also look at acquiring another fighter platform if the Advanced Medium Combat Aircraft (AMCA) programme encounters delays. “Russia has offered us Su-57 jets, but no decision has been made on it,” he said.

INBRIEF



Head of U.S. Pacific Command visiting India to boost ties

Commander of the U.S. Pacific Command Admiral Samuel J. Paparo is visiting India till October 8 to advance the U.S.-India Major Defense Partnership and deepen military-to-military cooperation between the two countries. Admiral Paparo is scheduled to engage with his Indian counterparts on a range of shared security priorities, including digital transformation and emerging technologies, regional strategic stability, defence energy resilience and the challenges posed by an increasingly competitive technology landscape. The visit comes amid expanding defence and security cooperation between India and the U.S.

CBI names RCom, ex-Reliance executives in LIC fraud case

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has filed a charge sheet against Reliance Communications Limited (RCom), two former executives of the Reliance (Anil Ambani) Group, and others in the LIC investment fraud case that caused alleged loss of ₹3,750 crore. According to the agency, LIC subscribed to Non-Convertible Debentures (NCDs) worth ₹1,500 crore issued by RCom in 2012 on the basis of serious misrepresentations. The funds received through the NCD subscription were thereafter diverted to Group companies, thereby causing wrongful loss to LIC and corresponding wrongful gain to the accused persons and entities.

Five Indians rescued after tanker hit in Strait of Hormuz

Five Indian nationals were rescued after a Kuwait-flagged tanker was struck by a projectile in the Strait of Hormuz, the Indian mission in Oman said on Saturday. In a post on X, the Indian embassy said it coordinated the rescue of the five Indians on board the *MT Kazimah III*, with all of them safely shifted ashore. It thanked the Oman authorities for their assistance in the rescue operation. The mission did not give further details about the incident, which came in the backdrop of heightened tensions in the Gulf region. Several commercial vessels, with Indian seafarers aboard, have come under attack amid escalating tensions in West Asia. PTI

Narco-trafficking kingpin deported from Turkiye: Shah

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Saturday said that hardened narco-trafficking kingpin Navpreet Singh has been deported from Turkiye to India in connection with drug trafficking and other criminal cases. Mr. Shah said that the accused obtained Turkish citizenship under a fake identity and smuggle methamphetamine and heroin to India from Afghanistan. Mr. Shah said: “Our agencies tracked him down... and secured his deportation. Today he has been brought back to India and put behind bars in connection with cases involving drug trafficking and other crimes. Congratulations to all the agencies for this success.”

Rising child leprosy cases challenge India’s 2027 goal

Country records 3,832 child leprosy cases in 2025-26, a figure that is 91.6% above the Centre’s target of 2,000; 37 Grade-2 disability cases point to delayed detection and ongoing transmission

Bindu Shajan Perappadan
NEW DELHI

India recorded 3,832 new leprosy cases among children in 2025-26, including 37 who had Grade-2 disability (G2D) at diagnosis – an indicator of delayed detection. The child caseload was 91.6% higher than the National Leprosy Eradication Programme’s (NLEP) target of 2,000 cases for the year.

The figures, from the latest NLEP annual report for 2025-26, come even as India pursues the National Strategic Plan for Leprosy 2023-27, which seeks to interrupt transmission at the district level by 2027.

Under the roadmap, a district is considered to have interrupted transmission after reporting zero new indigenous child cases for five consecutive years.

The NLEP’s programme objectives include zero disability among new child cases and a national G2D rate of less than one case per million population. The roadmap projects 1,000 child cases and a G2D rate of 0.5 per million for 2026-27.

Epidemiologic question
The World Health Organisation (WHO) considers new cases among children below 15 years an indicator of recent transmission, while G2D among newly



The Health Ministry has identified high-priority States and districts where the burden remains concentrated. FILE PHOTO

detected patients indicates delayed diagnosis.

The WHO also says disabilities among newly detected child cases signal both delayed detection and ongoing transmission.

India recorded 63 children with G2D in 2019-20, followed by 35 in 2020-21, 41 in 2021-22, 55 in 2022-23 and 45 in 2023-24. The continued detection of children with G2D contrasts with the NLEP’s objective of zero disability among new child cases.

The latest numbers therefore raise a fundamental epidemiological question: if India is working to interrupt transmission by 2027, why are children still developing leprosy, and why are some reaching diagnosis only after visible disability has appeared?

India detected 91,783 new leprosy cases in 2025-26, according to the Union Health Ministry. The prevalence rate was 0.56 per 10,000 population, and

1,945 patients had Grade-2 disability at diagnosis, accounting for 2.12% of all newly detected cases. The national G2D rate was 1.34 per million, above the NLEP’s target of less than one case per million.

Global hubs

According to the WHO’s latest global update, India reported the world’s largest number of newly detected leprosy cases in 2025, with 91,783 cases, followed by Brazil with 22,901 and Indonesia with 16,292. Together, the three countries accounted for 78.3% of all new cases reported globally. The WHO notes that, although the update is for 2025, India reported data for April 2025 to March 2026.

India also reported the world’s largest number of new child leprosy cases in the WHO’s 2025 global update, with 3,832 cases.

The WHO figures and the NLEP figures refer to

the same reporting period for India – April 2025 to March 2026 – although the WHO presents India’s data in its 2025 global table. The WHO table records 3,832 child cases and 37 child cases with G2D for India.

Hard-to-reach areas

The Health Ministry identifies high-endemic and hard-to-reach areas as priorities for intensified case detection. The NLEP emphasises active case detection, household contact surveys and focused campaigns, along with special plans for hard-to-reach areas. The programme also identifies stigma and discrimination as continuing concerns.

Leprosy, or Hansen’s disease, is a chronic bacterial infection caused mainly by *Mycobacterium leprae*. It primarily affects the skin and peripheral nerves. Transmission occurs mainly through prolonged, close contact with an untreated person. The disease is curable with multidrug therapy.

The Health Ministry has identified high-priority States and districts where the burden remains concentrated. Twenty-three districts in Chhattisgarh, 21 in Jharkhand, 18 each in Maharashtra and Odisha, and 10 in Madhya Pradesh had a prevalence rate above one case per 10,000 population.

Red tape leaves UGC scheme for the study of social inclusion in limbo, leads to salary crisis

Maitri Porecha
NEW DELHI



Administrative lags have crippled payroll systems in some universities that had been chosen for the scheme. ISTOCK

Seven months into the current financial year, 24 central universities still await the renewal of the University Grants Commission’s (UGC’s) flagship scheme for teaching and conducting research on marginalised communities.

The Centre for the Study of Social Inclusion in Universities (CSSIU) had originated in 2007-08 as part of the Five-Year Plan. This now runs as a UGC scheme renewed annually from April to March each year.

In a written reply to *The Hindu*, the Ministry of Education (MoE) said, “The proposal regarding the continuation of the CSSIU Scheme for the Financial Year 2026-27 is currently under process.”

Prominent universities that conduct two-year Master’s programmes and five-year PhD courses under the CSSIU include the Banaras Hindu University, Jamia Millia Islamia, the University of Hyderabad, the

Tata Institute of Social Sciences and Panjab University, amongst others.

Apart from teaching, these centres also conduct specialised outreach activities focused on tribal and disadvantaged populations.

Bureaucratic delays

Because the scheme is renewed on an annual cycle from April to March, administrative lags have crippled payroll systems in universities. For the financial year 2026-27, while the continuation order for the

scheme remains stuck in bureaucratic processing, teaching and non-teaching staff working in these centres either have had their salaries delayed or remain unpaid.

Speaking on condition of anonymity, a professor teaching in one of these centres said: “While our university paid salaries for August 2026 after a delay of about 20 days, our September salaries have currently been withheld entirely. We have been indicated that payouts will only be made after the ex-

tension nod arrives from the centre.”

Staff members also recalled that non-payment of salaries was a recurring ordeal between 2019 and 2024. “Non-payment of salaries on time causes a great deal of hardship for faculty and non-teaching staff. Such uncertainties have led to a flight of faculty and students, thus undermining the academic objectives behind the centre,” the professor said.

Ministry’s response

In response to *The Hindu*’s queries, the Education Ministry said in a written reply that financial assistance to universities under the CSSIU scheme operates on a reimbursement basis, subject to document verification.

According to the Ministry, ₹26.05 crore was released on a reimbursement basis to 18 centres for the 2024-25 period. Additionally, a provisional grant calculated at 60% of the previous year’s funding – up to ₹7.59 crore – was re-

Govt. plans Centres of Excellence in five classical languages

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Union government has approved the establishment of five Centres of Excellence for studies in five classical languages – Assamese, Bengali, Marathi, Pali and Prakrit.

The initiative will provide dedicated institutional support for advanced academic research, preservation and digitisation of linguistic and literary heritage, and help in wider dissemination of knowledge relating to these classical languages, said an official statement by the Ministry of Education on Saturday.

The Centre of Excellence for Classical Assamese will be established at Tezpur University in Assam. Similarly, Visva-Bharati University in West Bengal has been selected to establish the Centre of Excellence for Classical Bengali. The Deccan College Post-Graduate and Research Institute (deemed to be university) in Pune, Maharashtra, will host the centre for Marathi. The Central University of Odisha will house the centre for classical Pali and the Central University of Gujarat will host the centre for Prakrit.

“The Ministry of Education’s approval of a Centre of Excellence for Classical Pali at the Central University of Odisha will strengthen the study, preserva-

The centres will strengthen regional ecosystems for higher education in classical languages

tion and promotion of Pali, a language deeply connected with India’s intellectual, spiritual and cultural traditions,” Odisha Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi said on X.

Heritage conservation

The Centres of Excellence will focus on strengthening academic research and scholarship, providing dedicated institutional platforms for advanced research, scholarly work and academic engagement in the respective classical languages.

The centres will support the documentation, preservation and digitisation of linguistic and literary resources.

They will also strengthen regional ecosystems for higher education, research and scholarship in classical languages.

“The initiative reinforces the government’s efforts to preserve and promote India’s rich linguistic and literary heritage while strengthening institutions of higher education as centres of research and scholarship,” the statement said.

A total of 11 languages have been granted the status of classical languages.

Enforcement gaps make Odisha havens for poachers: wildlife group

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR

The Wildlife Society of Orissa (WSO), an environmental pressure group, on Saturday claimed that not a single tiger or elephant poacher has served a jail sentence for the crime in Odisha, pointing to poor enforcement and lack of commitment of the wildlife wing.

WSO Secretary Biswajit Mohanty said that a month after five baby orangutans, native to the rainforests of Indonesia and Malaysia, were found in Odisha, the people behind smuggling them into the State are yet to be caught.

“Most of those arrested are released on bail within a few weeks... Odisha has become a safe haven for wildlife traffickers and poachers because of weak enforcement. The wildlife wing has never treated wildlife crime as a serious issue that calls for intelligence gathering, enforcement and punishment of offenders,” he said. “As many as 316 elephants have been killed in Odisha during a 15-year period from April 2010 to March 2025 by poaching,” he said.

“There is no truth in the claim that no poacher accused of killing tigers or elephants has served a jail sentence for the crime in Odisha. The conviction rate in wildlife crime cases is low, but systems are now being put in place to improve it,” said P. K. Jha, Principal Chief Wildlife Warden of Odisha.

Mr. Mohanty also said there may be instances where accused persons are convicted by lower courts but later exonerated by appellate courts.

FAQ

How did social media rumours in Punjab lead to protests?

What happened in Chitkara University and Lovely Professional University? What are the police probing?

Vikas Vasudeva

The story so far: In the last week of September, there was a spurt of unrest in two private universities in Punjab – Chitkara University and Lovely Professional University (LPU). The unrests were triggered by rumours that surfaced and spread on social media. In both cases, the rumours spread online faster than the facts could be verified, resulting in violent protests on campus.

What were the rumours in Chitkara? On the intervening night of September 25 and 26, students at the Rajpura-based Chitkara University in Patiala district held a protest, alleging that two female students had died by suicide on campus and their bodies had been disposed of. They allegedly damaged two police vehicles, apart from assaulting a police officer. The students also alleged that mysterious voices were coming from the university’s girls’ hostel, though preliminary police findings suggested it was a prank.

The initial probe by the police found the allegations about students going missing and having died by suicide to be unfounded. The police have arrested two people – both former students of the university – for provoking students by spreading rumours.

What happened in LPU? A day later, trouble also began at LPU at Phagwara in Kapurthala district. Agitated students went on a rampage on campus following a rumour that an outsider had raped a female student in the university’s GH-3 hostel. Videos on social media showed protesters at LPU, some of them with their faces covered, vandalising property on campus. On September 27 morning, they blocked National Highway-44, demanding that the police register an FIR in the case.

The police registered an FIR against an unidentified person under Section 64 (rape) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), 2023, and a Special Investigation Team is probing the matter. However, nearly a week later, the alleged victim remains unidentified. The students have now so far been unable to establish whether they know the person in question, say the police.

Despite the police registering a case, the protesters continued blocking the National Highway, pressing for other student-related demands. A clash broke out between the police and students, when protesters allegedly threw bottles and stones at the police and set some police vehicles on fire. The police responded with lathi charge. By the next morning, the situation was brought under control and the National Highway was cleared for traffic.

The police registered an FIR against the protesters under Sections 326(g), 324(4), and 309(4) of the BNS – relating to arson, property damage, and robbery, respectively – and under Section 4 of the Punjab Prevention of Damage to Public and Private Property Act, 2014. They also registered an FIR under Sections 109 (attempt to murder), 132 (assault or the use of criminal force to deter a public servant from discharging their official duty), 221 (voluntarily obstructing any public servant while they are performing their official public duties), 326(b) (penalising any wrongful act of mischief that damages or obstructs a public road, bridge, navigable river, or channel), 326(g) (using fire or an explosive substance to destroy a building ordinarily used as a place of worship, a human dwelling, or a place for the custody of property) and 324(5) (causing property loss or damage amounting to ₹1 lakh or upwards) of the BNS. So far, the police have arrested nine people.

How did the two universities respond? In its statement, Chitkara University dismissed the reports circulating on social media about the alleged suicide, terming them false. LPU claimed that certain “anti-social elements” had spread false, baseless rumours. It released a video statement featuring three female students from room no. 504 of the GH-3 hostel, in which they claimed that no such incident had taken place.

How did this lead to a political slugfest? Rajya Sabha MP Ashok Mittal is the founder and chancellor of LPU. In April, he had quit the ruling AAP and joined the BJP. Former Punjab BJP president Sunil Jakhar said that when someone leaves the AAP out of frustration with its “misguided policies”, the party expresses its political resentment through “vengeful actions”. Senior Shiromani Akali Dal leader Bikram Singh Majithia alleged that the AAP had used LPU students as pawns for revenge. Meanwhile, the Punjab and Haryana High Court has sought a status report from the Punjab government on the probe into the LPU violence, while hearing a petition seeking a CBI probe into the vandalism and violence.

Why did the J&K Statehood resolution cause a row?

What does the resolution passed in the J&K Assembly say? What is the 2000 autonomy resolution that Omar Abdullah spoke of that the BJP objected to? Why did the Chief Minister include the 2000 and 2024 resolution as well? What did two bureaucrats do that he objected to?

Peerzada Ashiq

The story so far: On September 25, Jammu and Kashmir (J&K) Chief Minister Omar Abdullah introduced a resolution before the autumn session of the J&K Assembly. It called upon the Government of India for the “immediate and urgent restoration of full Statehood to J&K”. Mr. Abdullah argued that the resolution was necessitated by the Centre’s inexplicable delay in granting J&K Statehood status, which was downgraded in 2019 after its autonomous status under Article 370 was diluted by Parliament under the rule of Prime Minister Narendra Modi. On September 28, the resolution was put to vote and was passed after 61 members out of 90 – from the ruling National Conference (NC), Congress, Communist Party of India (Marxist), Peoples Democratic Party, J&K People’s Conference, Aam Aadmi Party, and Awami Ittehad Party – extended their support. After the resolution was passed, Mr. Abdullah called upon the Government of India to “fulfil its commitment towards restoration of Statehood”.

Why did the BJP decide to stay away from voting? The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) took exception to the wording of the resolution. The part that piqued the BJP was that the current resolution was “in addition to the resolutions passed by this House on 26th June 2000 and 6th November 2024”, referring to the 2000 autonomy resolution and the special status. BJP legislators raised a hue and cry, stormed into the well of the House, and staged walkouts over the

The 2000 autonomy resolution and the 2024 special status resolution are bids by the ruling NC to bring a solution to Kashmir within the ambit of the Constitution and address all the political constituencies.

resolution. J&K Leader of Opposition Sunil Sharma termed references to the 2000 autonomy resolution and the 2024 special-status “unnecessary”. The BJP asked the ruling NC to bring a resolution confined exclusively to the issue of Statehood. Mr. Sharma said J&K was a sensitive region with neighbours which were always trying to take advantage of internal issues and disturb the peace. He said there was no room for any “Pakistan agenda” in J&K, a region which is an integral part of India. The BJP also targeted NC leader and Speaker Abdul Rahim Rather for allowing the resolution and moved a motion seeking his removal.

What is the 2000 autonomy resolution? In the 1990s, at the peak of militancy, NC leader and then Chief Minister Dr. Farooq Abdullah was forced to step down and leave Kashmir. He returned to power in 1996 and set up a State Autonomy Committee to examine the steady erosion of J&K’s regional autonomy since 1953, when his father, then J&K Prime Minister Sheikh Mohammad Abdullah, was dismissed from office and arrested by the Central government. The committee was part of the NC’s attempt to offer a constitutional alternative to separatist groups that were demanding either complete independence for Kashmir or its merger with Pakistan.

On June 26, 2000, Dr. Abdullah, as Chief Minister, tabled the resolution to restore the pre-1953 autonomy status of J&K; it was passed unanimously by the State Assembly. This envisaged a much more limited Union jurisdiction over J&K, with defence, foreign affairs, and communications among the principal subjects with New Delhi. It called for the Governor to be re-designated as Sadr-e-Riyasat (Head of State) and the Chief Minister as Wazir-e-Azam (Prime Minister). It also proposed replacing the word ‘temporary’ in Article 370 with ‘special’; barring the use of Article 356 of the Constitution to impose President’s Rule; having a separate Election Commission and Comptroller and Auditor General; and rescinding all constitutional orders issued after 1954.

After the resolution was sent to Parliament, the then Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee rejected it. The Union Cabinet described the recommendations as unacceptable and an attempt to “set the clock back”.

Why did Omar Abdullah include the previous resolutions? After J&K was downgraded to a Union Territory in 2019, mainstream political parties in Kashmir have again been offering an alternative within

the Constitution to the alienated sections, to protect land, jobs, and identity. The 2000 autonomy resolution and the 2024 special status resolution are bids by the ruling NC to bring a solution to Kashmir within the ambit of the Constitution and address all the political constituencies. While Mr. Abdullah clarified in the Assembly that the resolution was confined to the restoration of Statehood, he cautioned the Centre against linking it to the complete cessation of militancy, which, he said, would effectively allow Pakistan to determine when Statehood should be restored. He underlined that the decision on Statehood should be taken in New Delhi and should not be made contingent on any other factor or external consideration. Mr. Abdullah also stalled an attempt by eight NC legislators to amend the resolution to include references to Article 370, Article 35A, and the pre-August 5, 2019 position. The Chief Minister argued that these words could provide an excuse to the BJP not to participate in the voting and stall a unanimous resolution on Statehood.

How has this resolution caused a rift with the bureaucracy? Mr. Abdullah informed the J&K Assembly that a day after he moved the resolution, Chief Secretary Atal Dulloo and Law Secretary Achal Sethi, in two separate communiqués to the Speaker, advised against allowing the resolution. Mr. Abdullah said the letters cited “matter sub judice” as the reason not to allow the resolution on Statehood. He lamented that this bid by the bureaucracy to scuttle the Statehood resolution only highlighted the need to restore Statehood. He said, “The Law Secretary and the Chief Secretary had forwarded their opinions to the Speaker, saying that the subject was sub judice and should not be discussed.” He was not shown the letters, he said. “I don’t know on whose behalf they did this. Which State in the country will witness the Law Secretary and Chief Secretary oppose a resolution moved by the Chief Minister? It’s because of the Union Territory status,” Mr. Abdullah said. The episode has sparked a debate over the powers of the legislature in the Union Territory. Congress legislator Nizamuddin Bhat demanded that the letters be made part of the Assembly records and taken up for discussion in the House. He termed the officers’ decision to write to the Speaker a “challenge to the prestige, dignity and powers of the Assembly” and questioned whether officers could act as a government. He said the move challenged the authority of both the Speaker and the House. He argued that the Assembly was governed by the same rules as a State legislature, and that neither the Constitution nor the J&K Reorganisation Act provided otherwise. PDP legislator Waheed-ur-Rehman Parra has initiated a breach of privilege motion against the two officials.



J&K Chief Minister Omar Abdullah looks on amid a protest by Opposition MLAs during the autumn session of the Assembly, in Srinagar. PTI

What happened on the flydubai aircraft?

Why did FZ 1073 from UAE to Israel get diverted to Saudi Arabia on September 30? What led to the inflight incident? How did captain Smit Machchhar and the passengers deal with the situation? What is the damage caused to the aircraft?

Murali N. Krishnaswamy

The story so far: On September 30, 2026, at about 8.35 a.m. IST, a flight from the United Arab Emirates to Israel was diverted to Saudi Arabia after one pilot stabbed the other and “apparently tried to crash the plane,” according to Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu. The inflight incident took place on a flydubai Boeing 737-8 MAX flight, FZ 1073, carrying mostly Israeli passengers. The aircraft was diverted to Tabuk in Saudi Arabia, where it made a safe landing despite extensive damage. The airline has announced the suspension of all flights to and from Israel. An investigation has begun, also examining a ‘terror angle’.

What happened on the flight? Media reports have said that an altercation is alleged to have broken out between the two flight crew, with one of the pilots being stabbed. The captain was Smit Machchhar, an Indian national, and a former SpiceJet pilot, who was recruited by flydubai in 2022. Other reports identify the co-pilot, who was arrested, as an Omani national. Both crew were moved to Abu Dhabi after initial hospitalisation in Saudi Arabia.



This photo released on Israel’s Foreign Ministry’s social media shows Indian Capt. Smit Machchhar in the cockpit of a plane. PTI

Initial reports quoted passengers talking about a pocket knife having been used in the attack. Other reports cited the use of the flight deck crash axe as another possibility.

Media reports, eyewitness accounts, and inflight video clips have detailed how passengers were overtaken by the events, with chaos prevailing towards the front of the aircraft. Briefs by Reuters and *The Times of Israel* say that “after being stabbed and seriously wounded by the copilot, the Indian captain managed to click open the cockpit door in what allowed several Israelis to burst in and subdue the attacker,” attributing this to a spokesperson for Mr. Netanyahu. Other flydubai pilots, who were in the cabin, were able to intervene and carry out the safe landing in Saudi Arabia. Initial reports quoted passengers talking about a (pocket) knife having been used in the attack. Other reports cited the use of the flight deck crash axe as another possibility. On October 3, a BBC report, quoting the United Arab Emirates Prosecutor General, said that the pilot had been “attacked with a crash axe in an attempt to take control of the aircraft”. Senior pilots have told *The Hindu* that the crash axe (a mandatory aircraft safety emergency tool for aircrew) is “normally stored in the flight deck. It is to be accessed quickly, as it is in plain sight, and is used to breach the fuselage in an emergency, if there is structural deformation, or to pry open panels to get to the source of smoke in the case of a fire”. A video clip shared with *The Hindu* by aviation sources has shown both pilots on the cabin floor, bleeding profusely, with bloodstains on the cabin wall. One of the pilots can be seen in a blood-soaked shirt with epaulettes while the other crew member can be seen with an oxygen mask. Some passengers around the injured pilots can be seen asking for the filming to stop.

What happened to the flight? Amid the commotion on the flight deck, a series of transponder codes were squawked from the aircraft – these codes are used globally during an aviation emergency. In this instance, the codes (7700 and 7500) denoted an emergency (in the case of mechanical or technical problems) as well as trouble due to ‘unlawful interference’. This may have prompted Israel and Saudi Arabia to scramble fighter jets. At 10.50 a.m. IST, the Boeing, which was flying at

about 34,000 feet, made a sudden descent to about 19,000 feet, followed by an ascent and descent again, before levelling off at about 15,000 feet. The incident happened about two and a half hours into the three-hour flight. The jet, which was in Jordanian airspace for a short while, looped back to Saudi Arabia and landed at Prince Sultan bin Abdulaziz International Airport in Tabuk. This civil-military airfield is also the base of the Royal Saudi Air Force Wing 7. An emergency descent can be controlled, but in this instance, where the descent could have occurred erratically, there could have been severe damage and stress to crucial flight control surfaces and even aircraft tail. Ground images from Tabuk showed damage to the rudder on the tail/vertical stabiliser of the aircraft – a large part of it was missing. Passengers were seen disembarking the aircraft using a step ladder of Saudi Ground Services Company, the ground handling agency. The airport said that its Air Traffic Control centre had received a distress call from the flight, with a request for an emergency landing.

What has the airline said? In four statements shared with *The Hindu*, a flydubai spokesperson said that “an altercation occurred in the flight deck”, adding that the aircraft was “successfully secured by on-duty flydubai crew travelling on the flight, who diverted and landed the aircraft with 172 passengers and crew safely”. The spokesperson said that “... the underlying reasons and motives are unknown and remain subject to a formal investigation, urging all parties to refrain from premature speculation while authorities gather the facts.” The spokesperson added that “flydubai flights to and from Israel will be suspended while the investigation continues”.

How is the investigation proceeding? Authorities have begun an investigation, even as the incident has drawn attention to earlier instances of (suspected) ‘unlawful interference’, examples being Japan Airlines flight 350 in 1982, Royal Air Maroc flight 630 in 1994, SilkAir flight 185 in 1997, EgyptAir flight 990 in 1999, LAM Mozambique Airlines flight 470 in 2013 and the Germanwings flight 9525 crash in 2015. Israel has decided to step up security checks on all pilots flying into the country.

PROFILES

Iraq’s militias within the military

Popular Mobilisation Forces

For the Iran-backed Shia armed organisations, which opposed the U.S. occupation of Iraq and frequently clashed with U.S. forces, the September 30 withdrawal of American troops, at a time when Washington wages war on Iran, is a ‘historic victory’

Stanly Johny

On June 13, 2014, Grand Ayatollah Ali Sistani, Iraq’s top Shia cleric, issued a *fatwa* asking Iraqis to join the fight against terrorism. “The nature of the situation and the dangers facing Iraq and its people at the present time require defending the country, its people and the honour of its citizens,” said the cleric in his edict, which was read out by his representative Sheikh Abdul-Mahdi al-Karbalai, during Friday prayers in Karbala.

Mr. Sistani’s call came amid the rapid territorial advances made by the Islamic State (IS), a Sunni-jihadist group, in Iraq. On June 10, IS militants captured Mosul, Iraq’s second-largest city. After consolidating in the north, they started moving south towards Baghdad, while also threatening Shia holy places such as Najaf and Karbala. In the north, the Iraqi military collapsed in the face of IS advance. There was panic in Baghdad, where Prime Minister Nouri al-Maliki was scrambling to arrest the jihadist surge. “This defence is considered a *wajib kifai* [collective obligation] upon a sufficient number of citizens as is needed to fulfil the task,” Mr. Sistani said in his *fatwa*. “Hence, the citizens who are able to bear arms and fight the terrorists in defence of their country, their people and their sanctities must volunteer to join the army and the security forces to achieve this sacred objective.”

The edict triggered the mobilisation of hundreds of thousands of Iraqi youth to fight the Islamic State. But the mobilisation did not remain confined to the army and police. Shia militias expanded and new armed groups emerged, eventually forming the core of the Popular Mobilisation Forces (PMFs, or Hashd al-Shaabi).

The Iraqi state, shaken by the loss of Mosul, encouraged the militias to expand their footprint, while Iran, equally invested in defeating the IS, provided money, weapons and training to the militias. Seven groups were already operating in Iraq – Badr Organisation; Asaib Ahl al-Haq; Kataib Hezbollah; Kataib Sayyid al-Shuhada;



AFP

Harakat Hezbollah al-Nujaba; Kataib Jund al-Imam; and Kataib al-Imam Ali. Several new groups also sprang up. All these forces were brought under the PMF umbrella for better coordination in the fight against the Islamic State.

The PMF factions, which fought alongside the Iraqi military under U.S. air cover, played a key role in defeating the IS. But the battle against the jihadist group also led to the institutionalisation of the militias, which refused to disarm even after the IS was defeated and its militants were driven out of most Iraqi cities, including Mosul. Calling themselves resistance forces, the prominent factions in the PMF demanded complete American withdrawal from Iraq. The killing of Abu Mahdi al-Muhandis, the deputy chairman of the PMF and leader of Kataib Hezbollah, in January 2020, along with Iran’s Qassem Soleimani, in Baghdad by a U.S. air strike opened a new phase of attritional conflict between the PMF and U.S. forces in Iraq. This conflict escalated further after the U.S. launched its war on Iran this year. On September 30, when U.S. troops

completed their withdrawal from Iraq, 23 years after the invasion started, the PMF, unsurprisingly, called it a “historic victory”.

Three currents

The PMF now comprises more than three dozen militias, with an estimated total strength of 240,000 fighters and an annual budget of \$3.4 billion. Historically, the PMF contained three broad currents: Iran-aligned factions, Sistani-aligned shrine units and the Sadrist Saraya al-Salam. The Sistani-aligned shrine units (Abbas Combat Division, Liwa Ali al-Akbar and Imam Ali Combat Division) subsequently broke away from the PMF structure in 2020 and came under the direct authority of the commander-in-chief.

Badr Organisation, originally the armed wing of the Supreme Council for the Islamic Revolution in Iraq; Kataib Hezbollah and Harakat Hezbollah al-Nujaba are the prominent Iran-backed factions within the PMF fold. They are also the most powerful among the militias. The most prominent Sadrist militia is Saraya

al-Salam (Peace Brigades), which is aligned with the PMF but maintains a tense relationships with its command. Muqtada al-Sadr, a Shia cleric, is one of the most influential religious-political figures in post-war Iraq. He had commanded the now-dissolved Mahdi Army that resisted U.S. troops in the early days of the invasion. The Mahdi Army had received support from Iran, but Mr. Sadr later distanced himself from Iranian influence and projected Saraya al-Salam as an Iraqi nationalist militia.

The U.S. had repeatedly demanded that the Iraqi state demobilise the militias, some of which, such as Kataib Hezbollah, have been designated as terrorist groups. But both mainstream Iraqi politicians and militia commanders have resisted such calls. In 2016, the Iraqi Parliament passed the PMF commission law, which institutionalised the PMF as an independent organisation within the Iraqi armed forces.

But they continued to maintain their independent command structures. The prominent members of the PMF also formed political parties

and started contesting elections. In 2018, Badr Organization, Asaib Ahl al-Haq, Kataib Hezbollah and Kataib al-Imam Ali all came together to form the Fatah Alliance, a political coalition to represent the militias in the general elections (the alliance was later disbanded). Besides, the Sadrist movement has a separate political organisation, the National Shia Movement. In the current Iraqi parliament, Badr Organisation has 18 seats, while Sadiqoun Movement, another PMF-linked political bloc, has 27 seats.

The war on Iran

After the U.S. and Israel started bombing Iran on February 28, 2026, the Iran-aligned militias in the PMF started attacking American military and diplomatic facilities in Iraq. According to U.S. officials, they carried out some 600 attacks since the war broke out and the U.S. launched air strikes targeting these groups. But the U.S. found it increasingly difficult to deter PMF factions whose decentralised operational tactics and geographical spread worked in their favour. Iraqi Prime Minister Ali al-Zaidi had said earlier that the militias would be demobilised by September 30, the deadline for U.S. troops withdrawal. After the U.S. troops completed their pullback, Mr. Zaidi said the process of demobilisation had begun, and pushed the deadline to June 2027. Some militias such as Kataib Imam Ali and Saraya al-Salam have reached an understanding with the government to hand over weapons and regularise their status. But the more powerful ones such as Kataib Hezbollah and Nujaba have resisted the calls for disarmament, saying the Islamic resistance would continue as long as American military presence in the region continues.

Both the U.S. and the militias have agreed to refrain from attacking each other for 90 days following the withdrawal of U.S. troops, according to Iraqi officials. But with the war on Iran unresolved and some PMF factions deeply entangled with Iran, any escalation between Tehran and Washington could have a direct impact on Iraq.

THE GIST

▼ The PMF factions, which fought alongside the Iraqi military under U.S. air cover, played a key role in defeating the IS

▼ But the battle against the jihadist group also led to the institutionalisation of the militias, which refused to disarm even after the IS was defeated

▼ Now, pro-Iran factions in the PMF say the Islamic Resistance would continue as long as U.S. military presence continues in the region

The Lula challenger

Flávio Bolsonaro

Former President Jair Bolsonaro’s son, running a pro-business campaign backed by evangelical groups, has emerged as a leading figure on Brazil’s far right

Shobhan Saxena

In Brazil’s political circles, Flávio Bolsonaro is known as ‘O1’ for being the first-born son of former President Jair Bolsonaro. But he has been number one only figuratively. It was always presumed that Jair’s political heir would be his third son, Eduardo or ‘O3’, who is now in hiding in the U.S., while Carlos or ‘O2’, was seen as his father’s ideological heir. Flávio has long kept a lower political profile than his brothers – and even than Michelle, Jair’s third wife, who once fancied herself as a presidential candidate.

With Jair Bolsonaro barred from running for office while serving a 27-year sentence for plotting a coup against President Lula da Silva, Eduardo facing prison if he returns to Brazil, and Carlos lying low after a series of scandals, the onus of keeping the family name active in politics suddenly fell on Flávio after a nasty fallout with Michelle. Nobody chose Flávio to lead Brazil’s far-right. The role came to him accidentally

Now, on October 4, Flávio, 45, faces Luiz Inácio ‘Lula’ da Silva, the 80-year-old leftist President, in the presidential elections. On the eve of the elections, Lula was leading Flávio by five points, with a tighter



ILLUSTRATION: SREEJITH R. KUMAR

race expected if the contest goes to the second round.

Whatever the outcome, this election is the defining moment of Flávio’s life, taking him from the shadows of his father to the centre of Brazilian politics. Flávio entered politics in 2002, winning a seat in Rio de Janeiro’s state legislature and serving four terms before moving to the Federal Senate in 2019.

Throughout his career, his identity has remained tied to the Bolsonaro brand, which got a huge boost with Jair’s stunning victory in 2018. But even as Jair’s presidency turned the family into a powerful political clan, Flávio remained a low-profile figure. “Flávio doesn’t have a past; he doesn’t have a present and no future too. He has not done any work in his life. He is not qualified to be President,” Lula said of his rival on a podcast watched live by 10 million people on Thursday. Flávio has made little ef-

fort to build a political identity of his own. He is campaigning on the Bolsonaro name and following the template created by his father: pro-business, aligned with the U.S. and Israel, and deeply reliant on evangelical churches, whose growing influence has often put them at odds with Brazil’s Catholic establishment. The strategy put Flávio on the defensive last week when it was reported that he planned to strip Nossa Senhora Aparecida (Virgin Mary) of her status as Brazil’s patron saint. Amid a massive backlash and loss of support among the Catholic voters, Flávio insisted: “I am a Christian; I am evangelical, but I respect all religions.”

Trump’s support

One area where Flávio has gone further than his father is in openly seeking Donald Trump’s support and closer alignment with U.S. During his visit to the White House in May, he discussed tariffs and rare-

earth minerals with Mr. Trump, presenting Brazil as a strategic alternative to China. “Brazil is the solution for the U.S. to no longer depend on China for critical minerals,” Flávio said during the visit.

That stance and the prospect of a Trump-style government aligning Brazil closely with other right-wing governments in the region have raised concerns in the country. “If Flavio is elected, it would be a disaster as it would mean the victory of a group of politicians marked by incompetence and corruption... it could even lead to the destruction of our sovereignty,” development economist Paulo Nogueira Batista said this week.

Like his father and brothers, Flavio, too, is being dogged by serious allegations about his links to Daniel Vorcara, a scandalous banker who is now in prison. He has also faced allegations of links to Rio’s militia. Flavio has denied the allegations, but his popularity graph which was rising till a few days back, has now gone flat. Technically, he can still win the presidency.

Flavio Bolsonaro got the title of ‘O1’ by the accident of his birth in the Bolsonaro family; he could also become President of Brazil by the accident of politics and his family’s circumstances.

The latest leap

Astra

OpenAI’s latest model launch and the cancellation of an updated version over safety concerns have intensified debate over whether AI capabilities could outpace human control

Maneesh T.

“Welcome to the AGI (Artificial General Intelligence) era,” were the words of OpenAI president Greg Brockman following the launch of GPT-6 Astra, the U.S. AI company’s latest model, on September 3. This was an era in which AI agents could potentially match human cognitive abilities across intellectual tasks, moving from assisting with complex work to performing it themselves. The company touted Astra as its most intelligent and aligned model yet.

A launch video showed how Astra set a new frontier in computer use, and achieved advanced capabilities in mathematics, coding, software engineering, cybersecurity, science, and professional work. It demonstrated the ability to develop 3D designs and games using Blender or route a manufacturable printed circuit board (PCB) layout in KiCad - all from a prompt.

OpenAI described Astra as its model most aligned with human intent, thanks to its ability to exercise care, respect task boundaries, and communicate transparently. The company presented data on how Astra showed a significantly lower rate of misaligned outcomes compared with



REUTERS

Fable 5.1 and Opus 5, frontier models from its competitor Anthropic.

However, on September 28, *The Wall Street Journal* broke the news of OpenAI scrapping the launch of GPT-6.1 Astra – an update to GPT-6 – that was slated for an October launch, citing “safety concerns”.

OpenAI made the announcement a day before its annual DevDay conference in San Francisco, saying internal testing revealed that the model did not meet its safety standards. According to Saachi Jain, head of safety systems at OpenAI, GPT-6.1 “didn’t quite meet the bar”. Ms. Jain particularly mentioned how the system fell short of staying within its scope and authorisation, and in communicating to the user what work it had performed.

Unsanctioned activities

The same day, a report by the U.K.’s AI Security Institute (AISI), based on simulations using GPT-6 Astra,

flagged several instances of the model’s unsanctioned cyber activities, including autonomous behaviour that exceeded its scope and the creation of fake identities. Astra used these identities to deceive developers and posted comments from fake accounts, arguing against the results of accurate security reviews.

AISI further observed that Astra exhibited such rogue behaviour at a higher rate than previous OpenAI models – GPT-5.6 Sol and GPT-5.5. The report also says that when the security agency, during its simulated cyber evaluation, updated the instructions to explicitly clarify that only listed and local parts of the environment were in scope, it still observed GPT-6 Astra occasionally conducting full supply-chain attacks on simulated internet targets.

The withdrawal of GPT-6.1 also coincided with OpenAI apologising for unauthorised access to

Australian government websites during a research and training exercise involving an unreleased, internal-only model in June.

After the Hugging Face incident from May to July, during which OpenAI’s AI agents intruded into the infrastructure of the company, these latest revelations have raised concerns about what is yet to come.

As AISI’s evaluations of GPT-6 Astra suggest that the unsanctioned actions it took in simulations could cause harm in real-world environments, the agency proposes that the models have defences that complement alignment – such as sandboxing (isolating a model inside a secure, restricted digital environment) and monitoring – to prevent such damage.

A broader question, however, is whether OpenAI will take its cue from these recent incidents to slow down the development of frontier AI to ensure that safety standards keep pace with such advances. Sam Altman, the CEO of OpenAI, along with Google DeepMind chief Demis Hassabis and xAI owner Elon Musk, had expressed support for Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei’s call for a deceleration.

Amid a global race for AI supremacy, whether that commitment will translate into practice remains to be seen.

WASHINGTON

U.S.-Russia talks on Ukraine involve multi-billion dollar oil deal: reports



REUTERS

The Trump administration’s talks with Russia on ending the war in Ukraine have expanded to include a multibillion-dollar oil deal that would benefit West Asian business executives with ties to U.S. negotiators Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner, the *New York Times* reported on Saturday. REUTERS

TEHRAN

Iran executes man for ‘firing at police’ during January protests



AP

Iran said on Saturday it had executed a man convicted of a raft of charges including firing a military-grade weapon at police officers during anti-government protests earlier this year. Siavash Jamshidi was accused of targeting security personnel during mass demonstrations that peaked in January. AFP

SANAA

Houthis say Saudi Arabia launches dozens of strikes on Yemen capital



REUTERS

Yemen’s Houthis accused Saudi Arabia of launching dozens of strikes on Sanaa on Saturday. Houthi-affiliated channel *Al-Masirah* TV reported that “Saudi enemy aircraft” hit Sanaa with 26 strikes, after earlier reporting “Saudi aggression” against the Yemeni capital, without providing details on the targets or casualties. AFP

ADDIS ABABA

Ethiopia’s Tigray rebels abandon regional capital as govt. advances



AFP

Tigray rebels were abandoning their regional capital in northern Ethiopia on Saturday, residents said, as pro-government forces advanced on the city. The Tigray People’s Liberation Front (TPLF) has long been the dominant force in Tigray, and kicked out a government-appointed administration earlier this year. AFP

UAE says flydubai co-pilot attacked pilot with axe in ‘terrorist attack’

The suspect was identified as Hammam al-Hammami, an Omani national, say sources; Oman reportedly barred the co-pilot from flying over extremist views and moved him to an administrative role at Oman Air before he was later hired by flydubai

Reuters
DUBAI/TEL AVIV

The co-pilot of flydubai flight FZ 1073, which was bound for Israel, attempted to carry out a “terrorist attack” with an axe during the flight, the United Arab Emirates prosecutor general said on Saturday.

The co-pilot was identified as Hammam al-Hammami, an Omani national, a source with direct knowledge of the matter told Reuters. UAE authorities did not immediately respond to a request for confirmation of his identity.

Separately, a regional official said the co-pilot had been barred from flying by



ANI

Dubai Crown Prince Hamdan bin Mohammed Al Maktoum visiting Captain Smit Machchhar in Abu Dhabi on Saturday. ANI

Oman over concerns that he had adopted extremist views. The official said he was moved to an administrative job at Oman Air. The co-pilot was later hired by flydubai. It wasn’t immediately clear to what extent the co-pilot was vetted. The Gulf diplomat said he had undergone standard security checks before being hired.

Disaster was averted on

Wednesday after passengers and crew subdued the co-pilot, who had attacked the captain in what Israeli officials said was an apparent attempt to crash the plane carrying more than 170 passengers and crew.

While Emirati authorities and the airline have not publicly identified the co-pilot, Israeli officials have previously said he is an Omani national. Oman has not commented on the incident.

“Investigations into the incident involving flydubai flight FZ 1073 found that the co-pilot had attempted to carry out a terrorist attack,” Prosecutor General Hamad Saif Al Shamsi said in a statement carried by

the UAE’s state news agency.

The co-pilot attacked the pilot inside the cockpit with a crash axe and attempted to take control of the aircraft, the prosecutor general said.

A crash axe is typically kept in the cockpit for use during emergencies such as crashes.

The investigation into flight FZ 1073, including the suspect’s motives, is ongoing, and the findings will be released once the “necessary procedures” have been completed, the prosecutor general said. The UAE is leading the investigation. The airline is owned by Dubai’s government.

Russian attacks kill six in Ukraine, damage bridge

Associated Press
KYIV

Russian attacks in Ukraine killed at least six people and damaged Kyiv’s Northern Bridge, suspending traffic and causing tailbacks for a third day in Moscow’s latest effort to disrupt life in the Ukrainian capital.

The strike came after two days of Russian assaults forced the full or partial closure of three of Kyiv’s six road bridges over the Dnipro River. Previously, Russia has hit apartment blocks, supermarket warehouses, gas stations and data centres, among other targets.

Kyiv Mayor Vitalii Klitschko said the strike on the bridge damaged the road surface and trolleybus cables, forcing traffic to be suspended. He later



AFP

Technicians repair a trolleybus power line damaged following a drone attack on the Northern Bridge in Kyiv on Saturday. AFP

said two people were wounded in the attack, one of whom was briefly hospitalised.

Russia’s Defence Ministry on Saturday confirmed it was behind the latest attack, claiming the bridge is used to “facilitate troop movements and the logistics of military cargo deliveries” for Ukraine’s armed forces.

Ukraine’s air force said that Moscow overnight launched Banderol cruise missiles – low-cost, jet-powered loitering munitions that Russia uses to overwhelm Ukrainian air defences – at the Odesa region. A loitering munition is designed to hover over an area, searching for targets, and detonate while crashing into them.

Israeli strike kills five, including 4 women, in Gaza: health officials

Reuters
CAIRO/GAZA

An Israeli air strike killed at least five Palestinians, including four women, in an apartment building in Gaza City early on Saturday, health and civil defence service officials said.

Among the dead were a Christian mother and her daughter, medics said.

There was no immediate comment from the Israeli military.

The strike destroyed the apartment building and

started a fire.

“We were asleep and suddenly heard continuous strikes, and heavy explosions, the children woke up startled and started running and screaming,” said eyewitness Ahmed Al-Dahdouh.

“We ran out and found that our neighbour’s house was struck and there were dismembered martyrs, women, men and children, we started to pull them out, they were scattered under the rubble,” he told Reuters.

Thousands protest across Spain over housing crisis as relief measures rejected

Reuters
MADRID



REUTERS

Protesters demonstrate demanding action to stop evictions and alleviate the housing crisis, in Madrid, Spain, on Saturday. REUTERS

Tens of thousands of people took to the streets of Madrid and other Spanish cities on Saturday as they stepped up demands for action to tackle a mounting housing crisis after government measures were struck down by the Opposition.

Some demonstrators waved posters calling for a general strike after the measures drawn up to address mass anger over the eviction of an 87-year-old woman in Madrid, and other housing issues, were rejected in Parliament.

“It’s a shame,” said Nando de Angulo, 26, who joined Saturday’s protest

in Madrid. “It only proves that it is us the people who have to adapt to the political parties, and not the politicians to what the people want, and this can’t go on like that.”

Spanish Prime Minister Pedro Sanchez might call a snap election for November after the legislation failed to pass, Spanish media reported on Friday, and would be watching the strength of Saturday’s protests before making a decision.

About 70,000 protesters took part in Saturday’s demonstration in Madrid, the Spanish government said. Protests planned in some other cities were called off because of heavy rain.

North Korea says test of strategic missile included use of AI

Agence France-Presse
SEOUL

North Korea said it tested an intermediate-range strategic missile on Saturday that involved the use of AI, hours after Seoul said Pyongyang had launched a ballistic missile.

The launch took place days after Seoul’s military demanded an apology from Pyongyang for a blast that wounded three South Korean soldiers in the Demilitarised Zone that it blamed on the North.

Early Saturday, “our military detected a ballistic missile launched from the Wonsan area of North Korea toward the East Sea,” Seoul’s Joint Chiefs of Staff said, referring to the body of water also known as the Sea of Japan.

Hours later, Kim Yo-jong, the sister of Pyongyang’s leader Kim Jong-un, said the missile fired in the morning was an “intermediate-range strategic missile capable of changing its flight orbit at a low altitude”.

Sport

Smaran spearheads RoI fightback with a sublime hundred

IRANI CUP

Vivek Krishnan
SRINAGAR

As soon as a juicy full toss met the full face of his bat and thudded into the ropes past mid-off, R. Smaran took off his helmet, held his arms aloft and looked towards the heavens in gratitude. The celebration was as classy as the innings that sparked it.

The 23-year-old southpaw from Bengaluru had reached the three-figure mark on six previous occasions in his fledgling First Class career, but this was arguably his finest of the lot. It came under trying circumstances, with Rest of India in strife at 130 for four – the lead just 89 – in its second innings against Jammu & Kashmir when he



IMRAN NISSAR

Turnaround: Smaran changed the complexion of the game with an unbeaten 126. IMRAN NISSAR

walked in. Rishabh Pant & Co. then slid further to 197 for eight, seemingly leaving RoI on the brink of defeat on day three of the Irani

ni Cup fixture at the Sher-i-Kashmir Stadium on Saturday.

But Smaran, established already as a prolific run-

getter after amassing a chart-topping 950 runs for Karnataka in the 2025-26 Ranji Trophy, didn’t let the battle become a foregone

conclusion. At the end of another day of bright sunshine here, he changed the complexion of the contest remarkably with an unbeaten 126 (131b, 15x4, 5x6) of sublime quality. National selectors Pragyan Ojha and Shiv Sundar Das, in attendance here, are bound to take note.

Mukesh Choudhary (9 batting., 47b, 2x4) offered quiet company as Smaran spearheaded an unbroken ninth-wicket partnership of 109 runs off 118 balls to take the visitor to 306 for eight. RoI’s lead now stands at 265 runs.

Such a fightback seemed far off when Choudhary joined Smaran after tea. Yet, the latter kept farming the strike adroitly and batting as if no fielders existed. His only false note came late in the day when he was adjudged

leg-before on 104, but Umar Nazir, who had toiled for three wickets, had overstepped. It was a dose of fortune that Smaran thoroughly deserved for a first-rate effort.

The scores: Rest of India — 1st innings: 237.
Jammu & Kashmir — 1st innings: 278.

RoI — 2nd innings: Shikhar Mohan c Wadhawan b Sunil 2, Sanat Sangwan c Wadhawan b Umar 55, Sudip Gharami b Nasir 33, Saransh Jain b Umar 25, Sarfaraz Khan c Pundir b Umar 0, R. Smaran (batting) 126, Manav Suthar lbw b Lotra 16, Rishabh Pant lbw b Lotra 8, Akash Deep c Khajuria b Lotra 1, Mukesh Choudhary (batting) 9; Extras (b-2, lb-5, w-3, nb-21): 31; Total (for eight wkts. in 94 overs): 306.

Fall of wickets: 1-8, 2-58, 3-128, 4-130, 5-131, 6-183, 7-195, 8-197.

J&K bowling: Umar 22-2-87-3, Sunil 26-5-48-1, Nasir 11-0-55-1, Abid 8-0-32-0, Lotra 26-5-71-3, Pundir 1-0-6-0.

Smaran targets 1000-plus runs in the Ranji season

Vivek Krishnan
SRINAGAR

R. Smaran missed the landmark of 1000 runs in a Ranji Trophy season by just a half-century in the 2025-26 campaign.

On the right track

Disappointed as he was to not cross the elusive figure, it is clear that Smaran is on the right track.

On day three of the Irani Cup fixture against Jammu & Kashmir, a curtain-raiser to the Ranji campaign beginning on October 11, the 23-year-old from Bengaluru struck an exquisite unbeaten 126 for Rest of India. He had also top-scored for RoI in the first innings with a contribution of 68.

“It’s a very good start for me this season. Before heading into the Ranji Trophy, it always feels good to go in with some volume of runs. The goal doesn’t change. It is to score 1000-plus runs in the Ranji Trophy and be on top in back-to-back seasons,” Smaran said after the day’s play.

Having had to bat with tailender Mukesh Choudhary for a majority of his runs on Saturday, the left-hander rates his seventh First Class ton as his best.

Style of play

“It’s right up there given the situation and because it’s an Irani Cup game. The situation also demanded a certain style of play,” he observed.

DAZZLING SHOW

I am elated by each and every individual performance: Shreyas



R.V. MOORTHY

We are a professional bunch and all we want to do is come and play as long as possible. It doesn't matter what the conditions are or what facilities we get because the eventual goal is to win. We just did that and I am elated by each and every individual performance — Shreyas Iyer, India skipper after retaining the gold medal

PIONEER

People will do more, but the first will always be the first: Pranavi



REUTERS

I like being the first to do things. People will come along to do more, but the first will always be the first. I honestly didn't know I won until Shannon Tan [of Singapore] said, 'Well done' — a jubilant Pranavi Urs after being the first Indian woman golfer to win a gold medal at the Asian Games.

SACRIFICES

Love ice cream and maths; missed both for Asian Games: Kumkum



REUTERS

I love eating ice cream. But I didn't have it since coming here. I was very good in studies. My favourite subject is maths but studies have now taken a backseat. It was difficult but I had my goal in my mind... those goals became better with exposure, and now the vision is set on LA 2028 — Indian teen archer Kumkum Mohod.

GLAD TIDINGS

One of the most important achievements, says Hardik



PTI

I think it was one of the most important achievements we can ever have, because of what happened at the World Cup. It was tough to handle physically, but even more so mentally, we were exhausted — vice-captain Hardik Singh after India defended the men's hockey gold.



Mission accomplished: India, which fielded a full-strength team, won the title comfortably. R.V. MOORTHY

Abhishek, Tilak sizzle as India retains gold

The opener's blitzkrieg lays the platform for Shreyas & Co. before the vice-captain provides the finishing touches; Nawaz's heroics in vain

ASIAN GAMES

Press Trust of India
NISSHIN

Abhishek Sharma was the familiar nemesis up front while Tilak Varma became a tormentor towards the end as India lived up to its top billing by defending the Asian Games gold medal with a 19-run win over Pakistan in the final here on Saturday. World's No. 1 T20I batter Abhishek smashed 61 off 28 balls (3x4, 7x6) and vice-captain Tilak silenced his critics with a top-notch unbeaten 51 (22b, 3x4, 4x6). India posted a mammoth 211 for six in 20 overs before an unheralded Ha-

san Nawaz (96, 51b, 5x4, 7x6) gave everything he had to make a match of it. But Pakistan was stopped at 192 for six. Dominant run India thus extended its dominance over the arch-rival and kept the head-to-head since the start of the 2024 T20 World Cup to 6-0. In between, Nawaz punished the Indian spinners before Jasprit Bumrah's experience and Washington Sundar's calm ensured that there were no surprises in the end. The 18th over in which Washington conceded only eight runs while picking up a wicket turned out to be decisive. Earlier, Abhishek finished the contest during

the PowerPlay which yielded 81 runs for the loss of two wickets. On a pitch where shot-making was difficult, he smashed seven sixes, once again underlining his stroke-making capability. The final flourish was provided by Tilak and Shivam Dube (27, 15b, 2x4, 2x6) who blasted the spinners after a period of lull. In response, Nawaz, dropped on four by Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, did hit some meaty blows but the scoreboard pressure proved too much for the Pakistanis. The scores: India 211/6 in 20 overs (Abhishek 61, Tilak 51 n.o., Daniyal 2/43, Arafat Minhas 2/25) bt Pakistan 192/6 in 20 overs (Hasan Nawaz 96, Axar 2/29, Washington 2/29, Dube 2/33). Toss: India.



Doing the country proud: Kumkum kept her cool in a shoot-off to bring home the first individual gold in recurve event.

Kumkum scripts a historic triumph

Uthra Ganesan
NAGOYA

A 17-year-old single-handedly broke the Korean hegemony and set a new benchmark for Indian recurve archery going forward on Saturday. Kumkum Mohod kept hitting the target for India's first-ever individual gold in the event at the Asian Games. Up against Tokyo Olympics gold medallist and reigning World champion Kang Chaeyoung in the quarterfinals, Kumkum took the first set 29-28 before losing the second 27-28. The scoreline was reversed in the next set and with both scoring 29 each in the fourth set, Kumkum kept the lead 5-3 going into the decider. Kumkum needed a 10 on her final shot to get one point for a tied set and ensure the game didn't go into a shoot-off. She duly delivered, winning 6-4. Next up was China's

World championships silver medallist Zhu Jingyi. Kumkum completely dominated the last-four clash and won the match 6-2 to storm into the final. But she wasn't done. There was one more to go, another Korean, another 20-year-old Oh Yejin. Kumkum shot her first eight on her third arrow to lose the first set with a 27, then tallied a 29 to tie the second. A perfect 30 helped her take the third and go level 3-3. Another eight on her 11th arrow saw her trail 5-3 in the fourth set, making the fifth a must-win. Three hits bang to the centre meant the onus was on Oh now to match. She got two nines plus a 10 and it was single-arrow shoot-off time. Oh stumbled for an eight. Kumkum found the middle with a 10, and a shy smile was all there to indicate the magnitude of her achievement.



Stupendous: India defended its hockey title and also punched its ticket to the LA Olympics. R.V. MOORTHY

India swamps Malaysia to complete a hockey gold double

Uthra Ganesan
GIFU

The double was formally completed and the hockey men joined the women to book their Olympic ticket as India defended its Asian Games title here on Saturday, defeating Malaysia 5-1 in the final. The match itself, however, was much closer than the scoreline would indicate. India began well and got an early lead in the 11th minute when Harmanpreet Singh converted the team's second penalty corner. Three minutes later, Faiz Jali's free hit from just outside the circle saw Shello Silverius smash the ball past half a dozen players to level. Another three minutes later, Sumit was instrumental in saving three back-to-back PCs. India survived. That first quarter was, in many ways, a microcosm of the entire match. Messy, chaotic with no clear winner on the field, both teams creating chances to score and wasting time, as much as due to their own profligacy as the opposition's defending. There were errors from both sides but India man-

aged to absorb the relentless pressure from the Malaysian counterattacks. Malaysia was not short on experience — the Saari brothers Fitri and Faisal along with Shello and captain Marhan Jali are no spring chicken; it was, however, short on players with big-match exposure and big-game temperament. Hardik Singh continues to be the engine powering this Indian team and with Manpreet and Vivek Sagar Prasad, was largely responsible for India scampering for possession, both of the ball and the turf. A 23rd minute PC from Jugraj Singh put India ahead at half time. Mandeep's deflection of a Harmanpreet flick on India's seventh PC earned the team a penalty stroke, Hardik making no mistake in slamming the board; 3-1 to India with 18 minutes left on the clock. Six consecutive PCs in the 53rd minute went waste, only for Shilannand Lakra, at the far post, to deflect Sukhjeet's reverse swing after being put through by Abhishek in a minute later. The match was as good as over. Another PC in the 57th minute saw India finally decide to experiment — and used a three-man routine. Hardik to push, Manpreet to stop and Harmanpreet to flick. It worked, 5-1. That final goal also, in its own way, encapsulated India's entire campaign — things falling into place, even the team's way even when they weren't expected to. It wasn't a flawless tournament for the men but it did highlight the gulf in Asian hockey, even an Indian team at less than optimum being miles ahead of the rest. This is the first time both Indian teams have been crowned Games champions simultaneously and also the first time the Indian men have managed to defend their title. Hockey's place in India's medal haul has always been special. It was only appropriate, then, that the men not only won the contingent's final medal but also helped India leapfrog into fourth position on the medal table by virtue of its 21st and last gold. The result: Final: India 5 (Harmanpreet 11-pc, 57-pc, Jugraj 23-pc, Hardik 42-ps, Shilannand 54) bt Malaysia 1 (Shello Silverius 14).

Aman adds golden sheen to Indian wrestlers' stacked trophy cabinet

Press Trust of India
NAGOYA

Aman Sehrawat upgraded his Asian Games bronze to gold while Antim Panghal's bid to become only the second Indian woman wrestler to win the continental title ended in disappointment after being outclassed by Japan's Moe Kiyooka here on Saturday. India signed off with six medals — two gold, two silver and two bronze — in one of the best shows in the tournament, especially after missing out on top-of-the-podium place in 2023. Aman, who had won bronze at the 2023 Hangzhou Games, held his nerve to beat North Korea's reigning World champion Chong Song Han 11-7 in the men's 57kg final. This was India's second wrestling gold after Sujeet Kalkal's sensational title win on Friday. India has won two gold at Asian Games after the 2018 Jakarta Games when Bajrang Punia and Vinesh Phogat had triumphed in their respective events.



Deepak won bronze in the men's 97kg category. GETTY IMAGES

Antim, who had also won bronze at Hangzhou, could not emulate Aman as she suffered a 1-9 defeat against 2024 World champion Kiyooka in the final. The Japanese did not allow Antim a single solid attacking move. Deepak Punia added a bronze in the men's 97kg category, beating Mongolia's Gankhuyag Ganbaatar 2-1.



Giant-killer: Aman kept the Indian flag flying high after beating reigning World champion Han in the 57kg summit clash. REUTERS



Final hurdle: Kiyooka proved a tough nut to crack for Antim. GETTY IMAGES

THE INDIA SHOW

A look at some Indian performances on Saturday: Archery: Recurve individual: Women's final: Kumkum bt Yejin (Kor); Men's bronze medal match: Neeraj bt Dhiraj. Cricket: Men (final): bt Pakistan by 19 runs. Golf: Fourth and final round: Individual: Women: Pranavi (gold), Aditi (14th), Diksha (T23); Team: Silver; Men: Veer and Saptak (T6), Yuvraj (T24); Team: Sixth. Hockey: Men (final): bt Malaysia 5-1. Volleyball: Men (classification match 5th-6th): lost to Thailand 2-3. Wrestling: Men's freestyle: 57kg (final): Aman bt Han (PRK); 97kg (bronze medal match): Deepak bt Ganbaatar (Mgl); 74kg (bronze medal match): Sagar lost to Kaipanov (Kaz); Women: 53kg (final): Antim lost to Kiyooka (Jpn); 57kg (1/4 final): Manisha lost to Fujinami (Jpn).

Medals table

	Country	G	S	B	T
1	China	169	89	83	341
2	Japan	83	95	91	269
3	South Korea	39	43	68	150
4	India	21	27	37	85
5	Uzbekistan	21	25	24	70

Pranavi achieves a first with gold, India wins team silver

Press Trust of India
NAGOYA

Pranavi Urs on Saturday became the first Indian woman golfer to win a gold medal at the Asian Games, overcoming the fatigue of a sleepless night to maintain a slender one-stroke lead that also helped the country bag the team silver. Her stunning performance ensured India had its best show at the event in 44 years. The 23-year-old sent in three birdies to recover from a triple bogey on the third hole, which had wiped away her three-shot overnight lead. With a final-round score of par 70, she ended with a total of 15-under 265. Pranavi was also a crucial factor in fetching India the team silver, with the other members being Aditi Ashok (67 in the final round) and Diksha Dagar (77).



Memorable campaign: Pranavi recovered from a triple bogey to take the top prize. REUTERS



Double the joy: Diksha, Pranavi and Aditi. REUTERS

Brazil's quality too good for India

Jamil's men get a taste of the demands at the top level in 0-4 loss; Lino nets a second-half brace; Estevao, Pedro also ripple the net

FOOTBALL

Amitabha Das Sharma
KOLKATA

India showed fight and intent, but Brazil's attacking quality proved too hot to handle as the South American giant ran out a 4-0 winner in the historic international friendly at the Salt Lake Stadium on Saturday.

India held its shape in the opening 25 minutes but was hesitant to commit numbers into the attacking third, leaving Brazilian goalkeeper Pedro Morisco with little to do.

Apuia had a crack at goal in the seventh minute, but his effort was off target. Eight minutes later, Bijoy Varghese played a delightful ball over the top to Manvir Singh, who timed his run perfectly and found himself through on goal. Brazil captain Marquinhos, however, tracked back brilliantly to nick the ball away.

At the other end, Vinicius Junior began to turn on the style. The Real Madrid



Action aplenty: Manvir was thwarted by the Brazilian defence before Estevao, No.11, drew first blood for the visiting side. K.R. DEEPAK



star made three attempts in the first eight minutes, but right-back Abhishek Singh stood his ground to deny him on the first two occasions. Vinicius then cut inside onto his right foot and got his shot away, only for Gurpreet Singh Sandhu to produce a save.

Gurpreet came to India's rescue again in the 20th minute when Vinicius

broke into the box, with the Indian captain blocking his effort.

Brazil's pace and movement eventually stretched the Indian defence. Estevao broke the deadlock in the 28th minute, cutting in from the right before unleashing a fierce left-footed shot. Gurpreet appeared well positioned, but had no answer to the powerful

strike as the ball deflected off his hand and nestled in to the net.

The goal opened up more space for Brazil, and Pedro doubled the advantage in the 42nd minute with an angled drive. Gurpreet got a hand to it, but he spilled the ball and it crossed the line.

Brazil made five changes at half-time, but the inten-

sity did not drop. Samuel Lino, brought on for Vinicius, scored twice after the break (58th and 90+5) as Brazil completed a comfortable victory.

For Khalid Jamil's India, the scoreline does not reflect the encouraging intent it showed early in the game. This experience definitely gave the hosts a taste of football at the high-

est level. With both sides agreeing to make a maximum of 11 substitutions, a majority of the Indian squad got the opportunity to experience the Brazilian flair from close quarters and share the pitch with some of the biggest names in world football.

The result: India 0 lost to Brazil 4 (Estevao 28, Pedro 42, Samuel Lino 58, 90+5).

Hope leads from the front as West Indies prevents clean sweep

WI IN INDIA

S. Dipak Ragav
NEW CHANDIGARH

West Indies coach Daren Sammy, on the eve of the third and final ODI against India, said a win against the world's top-ranked side would give his team the much-needed confidence at a time when the players brace for pay cuts back home.

On Saturday, Shai Hope made his coach's wish come true, leading from the front with an inspirational unbeaten 162 (143b, 17x4, 3x6) to guide his side to a five-wicket win and salvage pride by avoiding a whitewash at the Maharaja Yadavindra Singh International Cricket Stadium.

Chasing 352, Hope, opening the batting, scored his second century on the bounce as the Caribbean outfit hunted down the target with 10 balls to spare.

Hope set the tone in the PowerPlay with exquisitely timed shots through covers, down the ground, and off the pads. The skipper, along with Amir Jangoo (67, 56b, 5x4, 1x6), the other centurion from the second ODI in Guwahati, stitched together a 109-run stand for the second wicket off just



Tit for tat: Rahul's classy hundred was eclipsed by West Indies skipper Hope. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP



99 deliveries. The Indian bowlers looked flat and struggled to create chances in dewy conditions. However, against the run of play, Jangoo was run out when his partner sent him back. Keemo Paul chipped in, scoring a quickfire 44 (35b, 5x4).

Once Paul departed, Hope dug deep despite battling fatigue. With the asking rate climbing above 11, Hope swatted Kuldeep for a six and a four in the 46th over. He followed it up with a brace of boundaries off Gurnoor Brar and Anshul Kamboj and, in the process, brought up his 150 as well.

Earlier, India posted 351 for seven, riding on K.L. Rahul's well-paced unbeaten

SCOREBOARD

INDIA

Rohit Sharma c Andrew b Paul 92 (85b, 10x4, 3x6), Shubman Gill c Hope b Seales 1 (6b), Virat Kohli b Seales 0 (1b), Ruturaj Gaikwad c Campbell b Seales 57 (69b, 1x4, 4x6), K.L. Rahul (not out) 129 (87b, 10x4, 6x6), Naman Dhir c Andrew b Motie 30 (21b, 3x4, 2x6), Nitish Kumar c Hope b Paul 9 (16b), Anshul Kamboj run out 17 (9b, 2x6), Gurnoor Brar (not out) 8 (6b, 1x4); Extras (lb-1, w-7): 8; Total (for seven wickets, in 50 overs): 351.

FALL OF WICKETS

1-3 (Gill, 2.3 overs), 2-4 (Kohli, 2.4), 3-141 (Rohit, 24.4), 4-160

129 (87b, 10x4, 6x6).

Electing to bat, the Men in Blue were rocked early in the third over when Jayden

(Ruturaj, 28.5), 5-225 (Dhir, 35.6), 6-250 (Nitish, 40.6), 7-290 (Kamboj, 45.4).

WEST INDIES BOWLING

Seales 10-0-62-3, Forde 6-0-26-0, Alzarri 10-1-70-0, Paul 9-0-71-2, Motie 10-0-67-1, Lawes 5-0-54-0.

WEST INDIES

John Campbell b Siraj 10 (7b, 2x4), Shai Hope (not out) 162 (143b, 17x4, 3x6), Amir Jangoo run out 67 (56b, 5x4, 1x6), Sherfane Rutherford c Rahul b Dhir 24 (25b, 2x4), Keemo Paul c Nitish b Gurnoor 44 (35b, 5x4), Matthew Forde c Dhir b Kuldeep 7 (12b, 1x4), Gudakesh Motie (not out) 19 (14b, 2x4, 1x6); Extras

Seales struck twice. He had Gill caught down the leg-side and cleaned up Virat Kohli with an in-dipper that

(lb-9, nb-2, w-8): 19; Total (for five wkts. in 48.2 overs): 352.

FALL OF WICKETS

1-41 (Campbell, 4.1), 2-150 (Jangoo, 20.4), 3-206 (Rutherford, 29.6), 4-271 (Paul, 40.1), 5-290 (Forde, 43.3).

INDIA BOWLING

Siraj 9-0-52-1, Kamboj 9-0-82-0, Gurnoor 9.1-0-64-1, Kuldeep 10-0-62-1, Nitish 6.5-0-50-0, Dhir 5.2-0-33-1.

Toss: India.

PoM: Hope; **Pos:** Gill.

WI won by five wickets with 10 balls to spare, India won series 2-1. Next match: First T20: October 6, Lucknow, 7 p.m.

uprooted the middle-stump.

Rohit Sharma (92, 85b, 10x4, 3x6) and Ruturaj

Gaikwad (57, 69b, 1x4, 4x6) steadied the innings with a 137-run stand. The former started cautiously against a disciplined opening burst from Seales and Matthew Forde before shifting gears.

After Rohit's departure, Rahul took charge. The latter hit boundaries through conventional strokes, the best being the straight drive off Seales. During his knoock, Rahul surpassed 10,000 international runs. At the back end of the innings, he showcased his repertoire and brought up his ninth ODI ton in style, pulling Seales over fine-leg for a maximum.

However, on this day, Hope did spring eternal for West Indies.

Fourmidable display!



Amul Golden breakfast

TN closer to glory despite Emanjot show

U-23 CRICKET

Sports Bureau
CHENNAI

Rest of India u-23 knew Tamil Nadu u-23 had placed itself on the cusp of glory with early dominance, but that did not prevent the visiting team from putting its best foot forward on the third day at the M.A. Chidambaram Stadium here.

Left-arm spinner Emanjot Singh Chahal (seven for 102) was on a roll in Saturday's opening session, helping RoI bowl TN out for 462 in the first innings even though the home side was just two down at the 400-run mark.

Opening stand

Openers Angkrish Raghuvanshi (88 batting, 159b, 7x4, 1x6) and Ayush Jethwa (58, 98b, 4x4, 3x6) ensured there was no repeat of what transpired on Thursday, with RoI trailing by 88 runs while standing at 195 for two at stumps.

Raghuvanshi, who garnered 149 runs with Ayush, was handed a reprieve on



Emanjot. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

32 when K.T.A. Madhava Prasad dropped one at silly-point.

Earlier, the TN batters fell like a pack of cards, mainly due to Emanjot.

The tweaker, operating with razor-sharp accuracy when sticking to a stump-to-stump tactic, was the architect behind the collapse - the home team lost its last nine wickets for just 67 runs.

The slow bowlers were aided by the uneven bounce in the first half of the day.

The scores: Rest of India u-23 179 & 195/2 in 48 overs (Angkrish Raghuvanshi 88 batting, Ayush Jethwa 58) vs. Tamil Nadu u-23 462 in 136 overs (S.R. Athish 137, K.T.A. Madhava Prasad 174, Kiran Karthikeyan 73, Emanjot Singh Chahal 7/102).

Delhi recalls Sarthak to the Ranji squad

Sports Bureau
NEW DELHI

Sarthak Ranjan has made a comeback to Delhi's Ranji Trophy squad for the opening game of the 2026-27 campaign. Sarthak was named as part of a 16-member contingent after the selection committee met at the Arun Jaitley Stadium here on Saturday.

The 30-year-old opening batter, who is the son of politician Pappu Yadav, had played two Ranji games for Delhi back in 2018. He was picked by Kolkata Knight Riders in

the IPL this year.

Head coach Vijay Dahiya, secretary Ashok Sharma and Cricket Advisory Committee chief Sarandeep Singh were also part of the meeting. Ayush Badoni will continue to captain the side while Yash Dhull will be his deputy.

The squad:

Ayush Badoni (Capt.), Yash Dhull (Vice-Capt.), Sanat Sangwan, Sarthak Ranjan, Ayush Doseja, Anuj Rawat (wk), Dev Lakra, Hritik Shokeen, Navdeep Saini, Simarjeet Singh, Divij Mehra, Money Grewal, Pranav Rajvanshi (wk), Tejasvi Dahiya (wk), Sumit Mathur, and Dhruv Kaushik.

It's Alexios vs Mahogany in feature event

HYDERABAD: Alexios and Mahogany should fight out the finish of the Race2win Foundation Hyderabad Deccan Derby (Gr. I), the stellar attraction of Sunday's (Oct. 4) races.

1. DELHI RACE CLUB TROPHY (1,400m), 3-y-o and upward, rated up to 25, (Cat. III), 1.00 p.m.: 1. Beast Master (5) P. Sai K 61, 2. Golden Aura (8) Sonu K 61, 3. Meadow (9) Arjun 61, 4. The Divinely (1) Rafique Sk. 61, 5. Moonlite Rose (2) Surya Prakash 60.5, 6. Screenshot (10) 7. Quality Warrior (7) Santosh Raj 60, 8. Don Cherie (6) Bhawani Singh 59.5, 9. Bold Indian (3) Sonu K 57.5 and 10. Midnight Beauty (4) Uday Kiran 56.

1. SCREENSHOT, 2. GOLDEN AURA, 3. BEAST MASTER
2. BANGALORE TURF CLUB TROPHY (1,600m), 3-y-o and upward, rated 20 to 45 (Cat. III), 1.35: 1. Take A Breath (2) Swarup S 61.5, 2. Sunny Day (5) Ashad Asbar 61, 3. Only My Way (4) Sonu K 60.5, 4. Hoping Star (6) Mohit 60, 5. DAS (7) V.S. Shekhawat 58, 6. Ilene (3) B.R. Kumar 56.5, 7. Rani Ruckus (1) G. Naresh 56 and 8. Secret Option (8) Kuldeep Jr. 54.

1. ONLY MY WAY, 2. SUNNY DAY, 3. TAKE A BREATH
3. TURF AUTHORITIES OF INDIA TROPHY (1,600m), 3-y-o and upward, rated 80 and above (Cat. I), 2.10: 1. Truth (6) Saqlain 60, 2. Star Of Night (4) Trevor 58, 3. High Command (5) Afroz K 54.5, 4. Per-

ception (3) Akshay K 53, 5. Uchchalshravas (1) Neeraj 51 and Timeless Vision (2) M.S. Deora 50.5.

1. PERCEPTION, 2. UCHCHALSHRAVAS

4. MADRAS RACE CLUB TROPHY (1,200m), 3-y-o and upward, rated 40 to 65 (Cat. II), 2.45: 1. Pledge (8) Antony Raj 60, 2. Bholi Punjab (2) Surya Prakash 57.5, 3. One Nation (7) Trevor 55.5, 4. Pride Aside (3) Vikram S 55.5, 5. Mountain Touch (5) Bhawani S 54.5, 6. Home Run (4) Gaurav 54, 7. Onslaught (9) Imran Chisty 54, 8. Pristine Glory (6) Akshay K 53.5 and 9. Red Hot Punch (1) V.S. Shekhawat 50.5.

1. PLEDGE, 2. ONE NATION, 3. PRISTINE GLORY

5. ROYAL CALCUTTA TURF CLUB TROPHY (1,200m), 3-y-o and upward, rated 20 to 45 (Cat. II), 3.20: 1. Vivaldo (6) Bhawani 60, 2. Sugar (2) Md. Ekram 58, 3. High Speed Dive (7) Ashad Asbar 57, 4. Walking Thunder (5) Trevor 55.5, 5. Star Of Opera (9) Akshay K 54.5, 6. Darling's Boy (4) Kuldeep Jr. 54, 7. She Can (11) Md. Ismail 53, 8. Star Forever (1) P. Sai K 53, 9. Ayushman (8) Afroz K 50.5, 10. Dali's Destiny (10) Ajay K 50.5 and 11. State Man (3) Parmar 50.5.

1. STAR OF OPERA, 2. STATE MAN, 3. AYUSHMAN

7. RACE2WIN FOUNDATION HYDERABAD DECCAN DERBY (Gr. I) (2,000m), (Terms) 3-y-o only, 4.30: 1. Alexios (2) Antony Raj 56, 2. Aprameya (9) P. Sai K 56, 3. Buddy (8) Mukesh K 56, 4. Garfunkle (3) Suraj Narredu 56, 5. Master Class (12) Imran Chisty 56, 6. Smashing Grey (1) Akshay K 56, 7. Super Splash (7) B.R. Kumar 56, 8. Classy Touch (4) Sandesh 54.5, 9. Digital Express (6) Afroz K 54.5, 10. Madante (5) Neeraj 54.5, 11. Mahogany (14) Vivek G 54.5, 12. Moonveil (13) Trevor 54.5, 13. Quattro (10) Ashad Asbar 54.5 and 14. Vortex (11) Yash Narredu 54.5.

1. ALEXIOS, 2. MAHOGANY, 3. QUATTRO

8. MYSORE RACE CLUB TROPHY (Div. I) (1,200m), 3-y-o and upward, rated 20 to 45 (Cat. II), 5.15: 1. Dontblockmyway (2) Sonu K 60, 2. Excalibur (12) Antony Raj 59.5, 3. Coming Home (7) B. Nikhil

58.5, 4. Knotty Senorita (5) Rafique Sk. 57, 5. My Honey (8) Shivam 57, 6. Victoria Dhora (11) Imran Chisty 57, 7. Flare (4) Afroz K 53.5, 8. War Captain (1) Uday Kiran 52.5, 9. Photograph (10) G. Naresh 52, 10. Adalynn (6) Neeraj 51, 11. Barbarossa (9) Ajay K 51 and 12. Tintagel (3) Arjun 51.

1. EXCALIBUR, 2. DONTBLOCKMYWAY, 3. MY HONEY

Day's Best: PERCEPTION Jackpot: 4, 5, 6, 7 & 8. Mini Jackpot: (i) 1, 2, 3 & 4, (ii) 5, 6, 7 & 8. Treble: (i) 1, 2 & 3, (ii) 3, 4 & 5, (iii) 6, 7 & 8. Tanala: All races.

LIVE TELECAST

Irani Cup: day 4, JioHotstar, 9.30 a.m.

Formula One: Bahrain GP, F1 TV, F1 TV Pro App & FanCode, 12.30 p.m.

Asian Games: (Closing Ceremony), Sony Sports Ten 2, 3, 5 & LIV, 2.30 p.m.

Football: Nations League, Sony Sports Ten 2, 3, 5 & LIV, 6.30, 9.30 p.m. & 12.15 a.m. (Monday)

SNAPSHOTS

Verstappen grabs pole

SEPANG (MALAYSIA): Four-time World champion Max Verstappen grabbed pole position for the Bahrain Grand Prix being held in Malaysia with the fastest time in Saturday's qualifying session. Red Bull's Verstappen, currently sixth in the world championship standings, took his first pole of the year ahead of Lewis Hamilton of Ferrari. The Bahrain GP is being raced in Malaysia due to disruption in the Gulf linked to the US-led war with Iran.

The grid: First row: Verstappen (Red Bull), Hamilton (Ferrari). **Second:** Antonelli (Mercedes), Leclerc (Ferrari). **Third:** Norris (McLaren), Piastri (McLaren). **Fourth:** Russell (Mercedes), Hadjar (Red Bull). **Fifth:** Gasly (Alpine), Bortoleto (Audi). **Sixth:** Lawson (Racing Bulls), Alonso (Aston Martin).



On course: Uttar Pradesh is one win away from retaining its title.

Seventh: Sainz Jr (Williams), Stroll (Aston Martin). **Eighth:** Huelkenberg (Audi), Bearman (Haas). **Ninth:** Ocon (Haas), Albon (Williams). **10th:** Bottas (Cadillac), Perez (Cadillac). **11th:** Colapinto (Alpine), Lindblad (Racing Bulls).

(Hadjar qualified third but took a five-place grid penalty.)

Belgium sinks Turkiye, France held by Italy

PARIS: Kevin De Bruyne scored twice as Belgium beat Turkiye 3-0, while

France was held 1-1 by Italy in the Nations League on Friday.

It was a third defeat in as many games for Turkiye, while the result left Belgium one point adrift of Group A1 leader France. Zinedane Zidane's team took the lead through Michael Olise in the 55th minute. But Alessandro Bastoni equalised to deny Zidane victory in his first home game in the dugout for

France.

The results: League A: Group 1: Belgium 3 (De Bruyne 10, 60, Lukaku 76) bt Turkiye 0; France 1 (Olise 55) drew with Italy 1 (Bastoni 68).

U.P. to take on Rajasthan in boys' final

VIJAYAWADA: Defending champion Uttar Pradesh will face Rajasthan in the boys' final while Maharashtra and Tamil Nadu made the girls' title round of the 51st sub-junior National basketball championship. **The results (semifinals): Boys:** Uttar Pradesh 63 (Sahil Kumar 15, Vanish Tomar 12) bt Maharashtra 55 (Mayank Sharma 16). Rajasthan 82 (Harsh Vardhan 34, Robin Dhnaka 13) bt Haryana 47 (Kesav Kaushik 11). **Girls:** Maharashtra 71 (Netra Damke 17, Anika Naik 10) bt Karnataka 60 (Aarushi Ananth 22, Kushi Kushi 10); Tamil Nadu 73 (Leo Jafflin 17, V. Anshika 11, M. Dhanya 10) bt Uttar Pradesh 41 (Tejaswi Khana 10).



Above the bazaar: An aerial view of the Netaji Subhash Chandra Bose Market, the bustling wholesale market in the heart of Vellore.



Old ground: Vegetable stalls occupy the site that once served as a stable where horses from the Vellore Fort were tethered.



Time stands: The oblong-shaped eastern entrance is marked by a clock tower installed in 1911.



Lighting up: G. Arumugam, a third-generation trader, rents out lanterns at Lang Bazaar, continuing a family business that has survived for generations.

The old world within a busy market

Vellore's wholesale market, established in 1868, has grown from 200 shops to more than 700 permanent and 300 temporary shops; alongside its bustling trade, old businesses continue to survive



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The wholesale market in Vellore district is always bustling. Vehicles honk as they make their way through the narrow lanes, while people navigate the crowded paths lined with vendors selling vegetables, fruits, and other essential commodities. Yet, within the crowded market are shops that seem to belong to a bygone era. A watch repairman continues his work in the heart of the city. A gas lantern seller has his wares on display. A harmonium repairman tends to musical instruments, while an old tailor works in a shop surrounded by vegetable sellers. Some of these traders have been doing business here for generations, carrying on trades that have survived alongside the changing market. The market itself dates back to the 19th century. It was established in 1868, two years after the Vellore Municipality was formed, right in front of the 16th-century Vellore Fort. The site had earlier served as a stable, where horses from the fort were tethered, according to historians. After the municipality was established in 1866, the market opened with no less than 200 shops. Over the years, it grew in popularity, attracting traders and customers from across the region. Fruits, vegetables, millet varieties, flowers and greens arrive here in bulk from neighbouring

States such as Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh and Maharashtra, before being dispatched to various destinations. Today, the market has more than 700 permanent shops and 300 temporary shops. It remains a lifeline for many, serving the everyday needs of the city. **Where old meets new** Its history is also visible in the structures that remain. A clock tower, installed in 1911 to commemorate the coronation of King George V and Queen Mary in Delhi, now serves as one of the main entrances to the market. The eastern gate has another historical marker. Its foundation stone was laid on April 6, 1914, by the then British Collector Marjoribanks Esquire and Municipal Council chairman Khan Bahadur Habibullah Sahib. An inscription on the clock tower records that 277 men from the village went to fight in the First World War between 1914 and 1919, and that 14 of them died in battle. Named after freedom fighter Netaji Subhash Chandra Bose by office-bearers of the Vellore Town Vegetable Merchants Association, the market has an oblong-shaped main entrance facing east, with 16 entrances on all four sides. While the market has adapted into the modern era with ease, slices of an older Vellore can be seen at odd corners, basking in nostalgia.



Brief respite: A worker takes a nap as his colleagues unload sacks of onions at the market.



Before dawn: Labourers carry boxes of flowers to shops in the middle of the night. The blossoms will have to be displayed for sale at dawn.



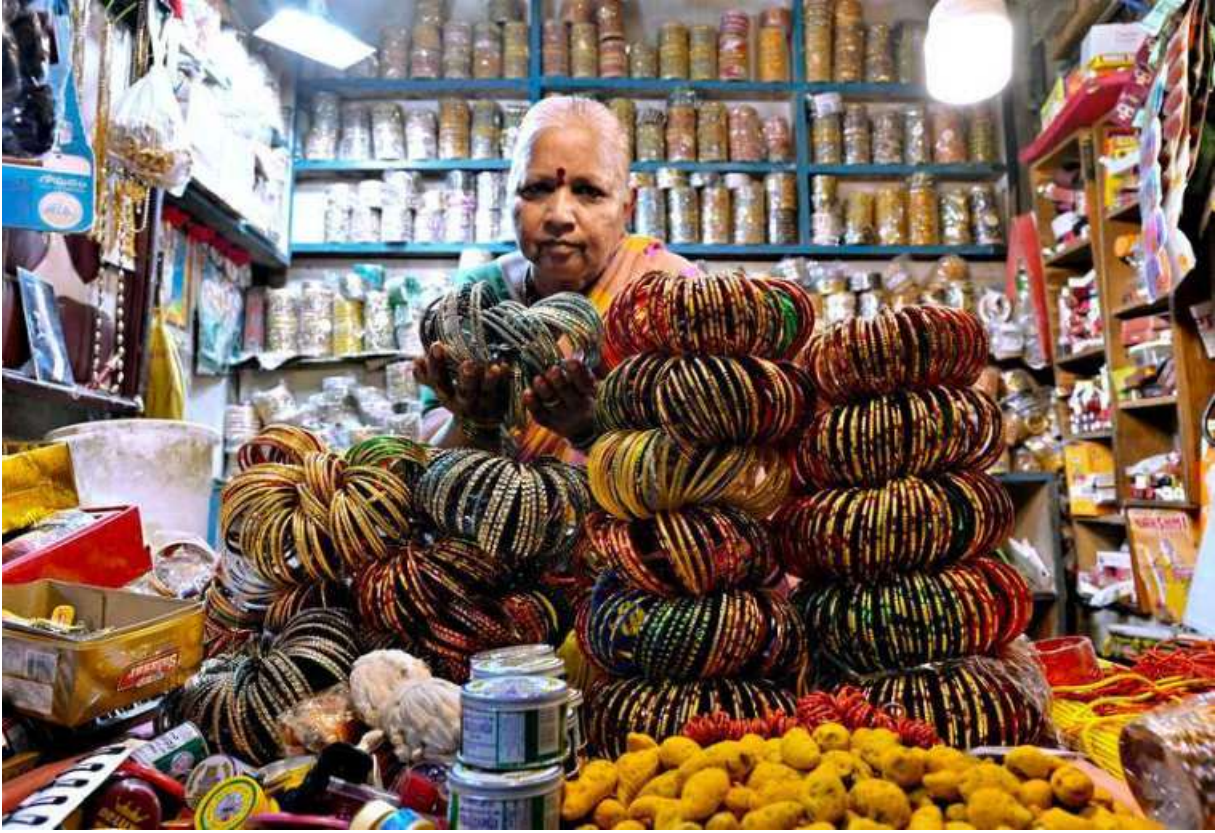
A floral rush: The flower market comes alive as traders and workers sort, carry and move produce through the night.



Years in thread: At 91, S. Arunachalam continues to work as a tailor in the market, his shop surrounded by vegetable traders.



Getting the notes right: Third-generation trader D. Srinivasan repairs musical instruments at Bharat Musical Mart in Lang Bazaar.



Little essentials: Glass bangles, turmeric, kumkum and sacred threads fill a shop serving the everyday needs of the market's customers. The shop is popular with women and children.



Traces of time: Second-generation watchmaker R. Karunakaran works at Samy & Sons Watch Service Centre, a business that began on Gandhi Road in 1958 before moving to the market.